

*The Tree Tells
a Story*



The Tree Tells a Story

A Four-Week Family Advent Devotional

MARTIN J. GALLAGHER

Christmas Tree Devotional

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*"The Bible begins and ends with a tree — and the
whole story of what God has done for us hangs
between them."*

Contents

Before You Begin

A Note Before You Begin	ix
-------------------------	----

Notes on Family Worship	13
-------------------------	----

Week One – The Tree

Why a Tree?	19
-------------	----

Session 1 · The Two Trees in Eden	24
-----------------------------------	----

Session 2 · The Tree as a Picture of Life	28
---	----

Session 3 · The Tree of the Curse, the Tree of the Cross	34
--	----

Session 4 · Fruit, Restoration, and the Tree of Life	38
--	----

Week Two – The Light

Do You See the Lights?	47
------------------------	----

Session 1 · Light Before All Else	51
-----------------------------------	----

Session 2 · Darkness and the Cry for Light	53
--	----

Session 3 · The Light Promised, the Light Arrives	59
---	----

Session 4 · The Light Embraced – and the Eternal Day	65
--	----

Week Three – Prophecy & Heritage

The Forgotten Ornaments	73
-------------------------	----

Session 1 · The Command to Remember	77
-------------------------------------	----

Session 2 · Prophecy Spoken – The Promise Takes Shape	83
---	----

Session 3 · The Cross Foretold — and "Today Fulfilled"	88
Session 4 · Forgetting, and the Heritage That Endures	94
<i>Week Four — The Gift & the Prize</i>	
Look at Your Tree	101
Session 1 · The Gift Promised	105
Session 2 · The Gift Anticipated	108
Session 3 · The Gift Arrives	111
Session 4 · The Gift Revealed and Received	118
<i>Back Matter</i>	
Further Resources	129
About This Book	131

A Note Before You Begin

Most of us set up a Christmas tree the same way we always have — all at once, in an evening. But what if there could be more? What if the act of setting it up, lighting it, and decorating it could carry your family through the four weeks of Advent as a living picture of the gospel?

This devotional began as one family's attempt to answer a child's question: *"Why do we put a tree inside our house?"* The result of that question turned into a way to relate the account of God's work throughout history, from Genesis to Revelation; from the Tree of Life in the garden to the tree of Calvary; from the darkness before creation to the city where there is no night. It brought greater meaning to our tradition and allowed us to point to Christ through it.

Advent is the four-week season leading up to Christmas Day, beginning on the fourth Sunday before Christmas. With this little book, each Sunday your family will gather around the tree and add a layer — first, bare branches; then, light; then, the ornaments of memory and faith; and finally, the cross-topper and gifts beneath. The associated scriptures open the meaning of each layer. Then, several times a week, your family can dig deeper into God's Word. This is a tradition that can grow richer every year. Read at your own pace; adapt freely; let the scriptures do their work.

Before the lights, before the ornaments, before the gifts — there is just the tree. Just the story of what God has done.



BEFORE YOU BEGIN



*Notes on
Family Worship*

*"As for me and my house,
we will serve the Lord."*

JOSHUA 24:15

Notes on Family Worship

The Simplicity of Family Worship

*F*amily worship does not require a seminary degree, a pipe organ, or a formal liturgy. It requires a Bible, a willing heart, and a few minutes that are intentionally set aside. The early church met in homes, breaking bread "house to house" (Acts 2:46). The Psalms were sung in households and around family tables (Colossians 3:16). And the commandment given to Israel was not to outsource the faith to priests, but to teach it at home: "You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise" (Deuteronomy 6:6-7).

If your family has never practiced regular worship together, Advent is an ideal place to begin. This devotional provides the structure, the Scripture, and the questions. You bring the family and a willingness to sit together regularly through the four weeks.

A Simple Format That Works

Read each session's passages aloud. Consider the reflection questions one at a time — don't rush. Pray briefly together to close. Most sessions run twenty to forty minutes, and the Sunday gathering can run a little longer. Consistency matters far more than length or eloquence — a short worship time that happens faithfully will shape your family more deeply than any single grand event.

Practical Suggestions

Choose a regular time. After dinner works well for many families — everyone is already gathered. Advent is a natural season to establish this rhythm before the new year.

Let the children participate. Let older children take turns reading Scripture aloud. Ask even the youngest children the discussion questions — their answers may be more honest and insightful than you might expect.

Keep it sustainable. Guard the rhythm jealously, especially at the start. You can always go longer when the conversation takes you there; you cannot force length when attention is gone. A rhythm that endures is worth more than a grand session attempted twice a year.

Don't wait until you feel ready. There is no right preparation. Open the Bible, read the passage, ask the question, pray.

"As for me and my house, we will serve the Lord."

JOSHUA 24:15

The Four Elements

Family worship includes four simple elements:

Scripture Reading

Read the passage aloud. For longer passages, divide the reading among family members.

Discussion

Ask one or two questions. Let the conversation go naturally.

Singing

A single verse of a hymn sung together. O Come, O Come, Emmanuel is particularly fitting for Advent.

Prayer

Close with a brief prayer — thanksgiving, confession, a request. Let the oldest child or youngest adult lead sometimes.



FIRST WEEK OF ADVENT

I

The Tree

"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; by his wounds you have been healed."

1 PETER 2:24

Week One · First Week of Advent

Why a Tree?

Preparation This Week

The first Sunday of Advent — the fourth Sunday before Christmas — begins the four-week journey. Find a Christmas tree (a real one if you can) and set it up in your home. This week, the tree stands alone: no lights, no ornaments, no decorations. Leave it bare. That is the point. Gather your family around it for worship using the readings below.

*E*very December, families carry a tree into their homes and cover it with lights and ornaments. Most of us have done it for as long as we can remember. But have you ever stopped to ask: *Why a tree?*

It turns out the Bible has a lot to say about trees. In fact, the very first pages of the Bible and the very last pages of the Bible both centre on a tree. And the most important event in the middle of the Bible — the death of Jesus — happened on a tree. Trees are not just background scenery in God's story. They are at the heart of it.

"The Bible begins and ends with a tree — and the whole story of what God has done for us hangs between them."

How It All Began

At the very beginning of the Bible, God created a beautiful garden and placed the first man and woman — Adam and Eve — inside it. In the middle of that garden, God placed two special trees.

The first was called the Tree of Life. It represented the life God wanted to share with the people He had made — a life of closeness with Him that would never end. The second was called the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. God gave Adam and Eve one simple instruction: you may eat from any tree in the garden — every single one — except this one. It was a test of trust. Would they take God at His word?

They didn't. They ate from the one tree God had told them to leave alone. And everything broke. Their closeness with God was shattered. They were sent out of the garden. An angel with a flaming sword was set to guard the way back to the Tree of Life. The door was shut. Humanity was cut off from the life God had intended for them.

This is what the Bible calls "the fall" — the moment when sin entered the world. It is the reason the world is broken. It is the reason we feel, deep down, that something is not the way it is supposed to be. And it all happened at a tree.

God Keeps Coming Back to Trees

After the fall, trees keep showing up throughout the Bible — always pointing to something important.

The book of Psalms describes a person who trusts God as being like "a tree planted by streams of water" (Psalm 1:3) – alive, fruitful, deeply rooted. It is a picture of the life God still wants for us, even after everything went wrong. The prophets – the men God sent to speak His messages to the people of Israel – call God's people "oaks of righteousness" (Isaiah 61:3), meaning people whose lives are strong, upright, and planted by God Himself.

But there is also a darker thread. In the Law – the rules God gave to Moses for the people of Israel – there is a striking statement: "*Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree*" (Deuteronomy 21:23). In that time, being hung on a tree after death was the most shameful punishment imaginable. It meant you were under God's judgement. It was a sign that you had been completely rejected.

Hold that thought. It becomes the most important thing in the story.

The Tree at the Centre of History

Hundreds of years later, Jesus of Nazareth – the Son of God – was executed by the Roman government on a wooden cross. The early Christians never forgot what that cross was made of. When the apostle Peter stood before the rulers of Israel after Jesus' resurrection, he said it bluntly: "*You killed him by hanging him on a tree*" (Acts 5:30).

Why did Peter use that word — *tree*? Because he wanted everyone to see the connection. The curse that was pronounced in the Law — "cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree" — landed on Jesus. Not because Jesus deserved it. He was the only person who ever lived a perfect life. But He chose to take that curse on Himself, so that it would no longer fall on us.

The apostle Paul explained it this way: Jesus "*redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us*" (Galatians 3:13). He took the punishment that our sin deserved, bearing it in His own body, on the tree (1 Peter 2:24). And because He did, the way back to God — the way that was blocked when Adam and Eve were sent out of the garden — is open again.

What was lost at one tree was won back at another.

The Tree at the End of the Story

The Bible does not end at the cross. In the very last chapter of the Bible — the book of Revelation — there is a vision of the world as God always intended it to be. A river of life flows from the throne of God. And standing beside that river is the Tree of Life.

The same tree that was guarded by an angel with a flaming sword at the beginning of the story is now open to everyone. No angel. No sword. No barrier. It bears twelve kinds of fruit — one for every month — and its leaves are described as being "for the healing of the nations" (Revelation 22:2). Everything that was broken in the garden is healed. Everything that was lost is restored. The story that began with a tree ends with a tree.

Your Tree Tells This Story

The Christmas tree standing bare in your living room is not a meaningless decoration. It is an opportunity – a chance to tell your family the oldest and most important story in the world. The story of how we were made for closeness with God, how that closeness was broken, and how God Himself came to restore it – all centred on a tree.

This week, as you look at the bare tree, let it speak. It stands stripped and unadorned, with nothing to cover it or make it pretty. That is exactly how the cross stood. And that is the point. Before the lights, before the ornaments, before the gifts – there is just the tree. Just the story of what God has done.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~25 MIN

The Two Trees in Eden

Begin Advent at the beginning. Set up the bare tree, then sit beside it and read where the whole story of trees starts: in a garden, with a choice.

A Garden With Two Trees

Genesis 2:4–17

God plants a garden and places two trees at its center — the Tree of Life and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil.

⁴These are the generations of the heavens and the earth when they were created, in the day that the Lord God made the earth and the heavens. ⁵When no bush of the field was yet in the land and no small plant of the field had yet sprung up—for the Lord God had not caused it to rain on the land, and there was no man to work the ground, ⁶and a mist was going up from the land and was watering the whole face of the ground— ⁷then the Lord God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature. ⁸And the Lord God planted a garden in Eden, in the east, and there he put the man whom he had formed. ⁹And out of the ground the Lord God made to spring up every tree that is pleasant to the sight and good for food. The tree of life was in the midst of the garden, and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. ¹⁰A river flowed out of Eden to water the garden, and there it divided and became four rivers. ¹¹The name of the first is the Pishon. It is the one that flowed around the whole land of Havilah, where there is gold. ¹²And the gold of that land is good; bdellium and onyx stone are there. ¹³The name of the second river is the Gihon. It is the one that flowed around the whole land of Cush. ¹⁴And the name of the third river is the Tigris,

which flows east of Assyria. And the fourth river is the Euphrates. ¹⁵The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it. ¹⁶And the Lord God commanded the man, saying, "You may surely eat of every tree of the garden, ¹⁷but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die."

REFLECT

1. Why do you think God placed both trees in the garden, and not just the Tree of Life? What does that tell you about the kind of relationship God wanted with Adam and Eve?
2. God's instruction was generous — eat from *any* tree, except one. How does Scripture's picture of a single restraint inside enormous freedom compare with how we usually think of God's commands?

The Choice and Its Cost

Genesis 3:1–24

The serpent, the forbidden tree, the fall, and exile from the Tree of Life — the garden gate is closed, the way back guarded by an angel with a flaming sword.

¹Now the serpent was more crafty than any other beast of the field that the Lord God had made. He said to the woman, "Did God actually say, 'You shall not eat of any tree in the garden?'" ²And the woman said to the serpent, "We may eat of the fruit of the trees in the garden, ³but God said, 'You shall not eat of the fruit of the tree that is in the midst of the garden, neither shall you touch it, lest you die.'" ⁴But the serpent said to the woman, "You will not surely die. ⁵For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil." ⁶So when the woman saw that the tree was good for

food, and that it was a delight to the eyes, and that the tree was to be desired to make one wise, she took of its fruit and ate, and she also gave some to her husband who was with her, and he ate. ⁷Then the eyes of both were opened, and they knew that they were naked. And they sewed fig leaves together and made themselves loincloths. ⁸And they heard the sound of the Lord God walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and the man and his wife hid themselves from the presence of the Lord God among the trees of the garden. ⁹But the Lord God called to the man and said to him, "Where are you?" ¹⁰And he said, "I heard the sound of you in the garden, and I was afraid, because I was naked, and I hid myself." ¹¹He said, "Who told you that you were naked? Have you eaten of the tree of which I commanded you not to eat?" ¹²The man said, "The woman whom you gave to be with me, she gave me fruit of the tree, and I ate." ¹³Then the Lord God said to the woman, "What is this that you have done?" The woman said, "The serpent deceived me, and I ate." ¹⁴The Lord God said to the serpent, "Because you have done this, cursed are you above all livestock and above all beasts of the field; on your belly you shall go, and dust you shall eat all the days of your life. ¹⁵I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel." ¹⁶To the woman he said, "I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children. Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you." ¹⁷And to Adam he said, "Because you have listened to the voice of your wife and have eaten of the tree of which I commanded you, 'You shall not eat of it,' cursed is the ground because of you; in pain you shall eat of it all the days of your life; ¹⁸thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you; and you shall eat the plants of the field. ¹⁹By the sweat of your face you shall eat bread, till you return to the ground, for out of it you were taken; for you are dust, and to dust you shall return." ²⁰The man called his wife's name Eve, because she was the mother of all living. ²¹And the Lord God made for Adam and for his wife garments of skins and clothed them. ²²Then the Lord God said, "Behold, the

man has become like one of us in knowing good and evil. Now, lest he reach out his hand and take also of the tree of life and eat, and live forever—" ²³therefore the Lord God sent him out from the garden of Eden to work the ground from which he was taken. ²⁴He drove out the man, and at the east of the garden of Eden he placed the cherubim and a flaming sword that turned every way to guard the way to the tree of life.

REFLECT

1. The serpent's first move was to make Eve question God's word: "Did God actually say...?" Where do you feel that same question pressed on you in your own life right now?
2. Adam and Eve are not struck down — they are *sent out*, and the way back to the Tree of Life is barred. Why does the Bible describe the consequence of sin as exile rather than only punishment?
3. Look at the bare tree in your living room. It stands stripped, unadorned — much like Adam and Eve at the end of Genesis 3, stripped of glory and sent into the cold. How does the bare tree help you feel the ache that the rest of the Bible answers?

Close in prayer. Thank God that the story of the tree does not end in Genesis 3.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

The Tree as a Picture of Life

After Eden, trees keep showing up — sometimes as a picture of the flourishing life God wants to give His people, sometimes as a warning about the trees that grow tall on their own pride.

Rooted by the Water

Psalm 1:1-6

The righteous are like a tree planted by streams of water — flourishing because of where they are rooted, not because of effort.

¹Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers; ²but his delight is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he meditates day and night. ³He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither. In all that he does, he prospers. ⁴The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away. ⁵Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous; ⁶for the Lord knows the way of the righteous, but the way of the wicked will perish.

Proverbs 3:13-20

Wisdom "is a tree of life to those who lay hold of her" — blessing flows from fearing the Lord.

¹³Blessed is the one who finds wisdom, and the one who gets understanding, ¹⁴for the gain from her is better than gain from silver and her profit better than gold. ¹⁵She is more precious than jewels, and nothing you desire can compare with her. ¹⁶Long life is in her right hand; in her left hand are riches and honor. ¹⁷Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. ¹⁸She is a tree of life to those who lay hold of her; those who hold her fast are called blessed. ¹⁹The Lord by wisdom foun-

ded the earth; by understanding he established the heavens;
20 by his knowledge the deeps broke open, and the clouds drop
down the dew.

Proverbs 11:28-31

"The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life" – the one who wins souls is wise.

28 Whoever trusts in his riches will fall, but the righteous will flourish like a green leaf. 29 Whoever troubles his own household will inherit the wind, and the fool will be servant to the wise of heart. 30 The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life, and whoever captures souls is wise. 31 If the righteous is repaid on earth, how much more the wicked and the sinner!

REFLECT

1. A tree planted by water did not choose its place — it was planted there. What does this teach us about how a flourishing life with God begins?
2. Proverbs calls wisdom itself a "tree of life." If the tree of life in Eden was lost, what does it mean that wisdom is now offered as a kind of restoration?
3. If your life were a tree, what fruit would the people closest to you say they have tasted from it this past year?

Two Destinies, One Choice

Jeremiah 17:5-10

Two destinies contrasted — the one who trusts in self is like a shrub in the desert; the one who trusts the Lord is like a tree planted by water.

5 Thus says the Lord: "Cursed is the man who trusts in man and makes flesh his strength, whose heart turns away from the Lord. 6 He is like a shrub in the desert, and shall not see any good

come. He shall dwell in the parched places of the wilderness, in an uninhabited salt land. ⁷"Blessed is the man who trusts in the Lord, whose trust is the Lord. ⁸He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes, for its leaves remain green, and is not anxious in the year of drought, for it does not cease to bear fruit." ⁹The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it? ¹⁰"I the Lord search the heart and test the mind, to give every man according to his ways, according to the fruit of his deeds."

Ezekiel 17:22-24

God Himself plants a tender sprig on a high mountain — a quiet promise that the Messiah will grow from a line that looks broken.

²²Thus says the Lord God: "I myself will take a sprig from the lofty top of the cedar and will set it out. I will break off from the topmost of its young twigs a tender one, and I myself will plant it on a high and lofty mountain. ²³On the mountain height of Israel will I plant it, that it may bear branches and produce fruit and become a noble cedar. And under it will dwell every kind of bird; in the shade of its branches birds of every sort will nest. ²⁴And all the trees of the field shall know that I am the Lord; I bring low the high tree, and make high the low tree, dry up the green tree, and make the dry tree flourish. I am the Lord; I have spoken, and I will do it."

REFLECT

1. Jeremiah's contrast is not righteous-versus-wicked but trusting-in-God versus trusting-in-self. Where in your week is your trust currently planted?
2. Ezekiel says God will personally take a tender sprig and plant it. Why does the Bible keep returning to the picture of God as the gardener — and what comfort is in that?

Trees of Pride, Cut Down

Daniel 4:10–26

Nebuchadnezzar's dream of the great tree cut down – God humbles the proud.

¹⁰"The visions of my head as I lay in bed were these: I saw, and behold, a tree in the midst of the earth, and its height was great. ¹¹The tree grew and became strong, and its top reached to heaven, and it was visible to the end of the whole earth. ¹²Its leaves were beautiful and its fruit abundant, and in it was food for all. The beasts of the field found shade under it, and the birds of the heavens lived in its branches, and all flesh was fed from it. ¹³"I saw in the visions of my head as I lay in bed, and behold, a watcher, a holy one, came down from heaven. ¹⁴He proclaimed aloud and said thus: 'Chop down the tree and lop off its branches, strip off its leaves and scatter its fruit. Let the beasts flee from under it and the birds from its branches. ¹⁵But leave the stump of its roots in the earth, bound with a band of iron and bronze, amid the tender grass of the field. Let him be wet with the dew of heaven. Let his portion be with the beasts in the grass of the earth. ¹⁶Let his mind be changed from a man's, and let a beast's mind be given to him; and let seven periods of time pass over him. ¹⁷The sentence is by the decree of the watchers, the decision by the word of the holy ones, to the end that the living may know that the Most High rules the kingdom of men and gives it to whom he will and sets over it the lowliest of men.' ¹⁸This dream I, King Nebuchadnezzar, saw. And you, O Belteshazzar, tell me the interpretation, because all the wise men of my kingdom are not able to make known to me the interpretation, but you are able, for the spirit of the holy gods is in you." ¹⁹Then Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar, was dismayed for a while, and his thoughts alarmed him. The king answered and said, "Belteshazzar, let not the dream or the interpretation alarm you." Belteshazzar answered and said, "My lord, may the dream be for those who hate you and its interpretation for your enemies! ²⁰The tree you saw, which grew and became strong, so

that its top reached to heaven, and it was visible to the end of the whole earth, ²¹whose leaves were beautiful and its fruit abundant, and in which was food for all, under which beasts of the field found shade, and in whose branches the birds of the heavens lived-- ²²it is you, O king, who have grown and become strong. Your greatness has grown and reaches to heaven, and your dominion to the ends of the earth. ²³And because the king saw a watcher, a holy one, coming down from heaven and saying, 'Chop down the tree and destroy it, but leave the stump of its roots in the earth, bound with a band of iron and bronze, in the tender grass of the field, and let him be wet with the dew of heaven, and let his portion be with the beasts of the field, till seven periods of time pass over him,' ²⁴this is the interpretation, O king: It is a decree of the Most High, which has come upon my lord the king, ²⁵that you shall be driven from among men, and your dwelling shall be with the beasts of the field. You shall be made to eat grass like an ox, and you shall be wet with the dew of heaven, and seven periods of time shall pass over you, till you know that the Most High rules the kingdom of men and gives it to whom he will. ²⁶And as it was commanded to leave the stump of the roots of the tree, your kingdom shall be confirmed for you from the time that you know that Heaven rules.

Zechariah 11:1-6

The cedars and oaks fall – judgment sweeps through the proud trees of the nations.

¹Open your doors, O Lebanon, that the fire may devour your cedars! ²Wail, O cypress, for the cedar has fallen, for the glorious trees are ruined! Wail, oaks of Bashan, for the thick forest has been felled! ³The sound of the wail of the shepherds, for their glory is ruined! The sound of the roar of the lions, for the thicket of the Jordan is ruined! ⁴Thus said the Lord my God: "Become shepherd of the flock doomed to slaughter. ⁵Those who buy them slaughter them and go unpunished, and those who sell them say, 'Blessed be the Lord, I have become rich,' and their

own shepherds have no pity on them. ⁶For I will no longer have pity on the inhabitants of this land, declares the Lord. Behold, I will cause each of them to fall into the hand of his neighbor, and each into the hand of his king, and they shall crush the land, and I will deliver none from their hand."

REFLECT

1. Daniel and Zechariah both show God cutting down trees that grew tall on their own strength. What is the difference between a tree God plants (Jeremiah, Ezekiel) and a tree that grows itself (Daniel, Zechariah)?
2. Where in your own life have you noticed God gently lopping off something that was growing on its own pride?

Close in prayer. Ask God to plant your family deeper in Him this week.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~25 MIN

The Tree of the Curse, the Tree of the Cross

A startling thread runs through Scripture: the curse falls on a tree — and the rescue comes through a tree. This is the heart of why Christians have always seen the cross when they look at a tree.

A Curse Spoken Centuries Early

Deuteronomy 21:22-23

"A hanged man is cursed by God" — the law that would one day point to Calvary.

²²And if a man has committed a crime punishable by death and he is put to death, and you hang him on a tree, ²³his body shall not remain all night on the tree, but you shall bury him the same day, for a hanged man is cursed by God. You shall not defile your land that the Lord your God is giving you for an inheritance.

REFLECT

1. Why did God put this specific verse in the Law a thousand years before Jesus? What is He preparing His people to recognize?

"You Killed Him by Hanging Him on a Tree"

Acts 5:27-33

Peter before the Sanhedrin — "the God of our fathers raised Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree."

²⁷And when they had brought them, they set them before the council. And the high priest questioned them, ²⁸saying, "We strictly charged you not to teach in this name, yet here you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching, and you intend to bring this

man's blood upon us." ²⁹But Peter and the apostles answered, "We must obey God rather than men. ³⁰The God of our fathers raised Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree. ³¹God exalted him at his right hand as Leader and Savior, to give repentance to Israel and forgiveness of sins. ³²And we are witnesses to these things, and so is the Holy Spirit, whom God has given to those who obey him." ³³When they heard this, they were enraged and wanted to kill them.

Acts 10:34-43

Peter to Cornelius – "they put him to death by hanging him on a tree" – and the promise of forgiveness through His name.

³⁴So Peter opened his mouth and said: "Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, ³⁵but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him. ³⁶As for the word that he sent to Israel, preaching good news of peace through Jesus Christ (he is Lord of all), ³⁷you yourselves know what happened throughout all Judea, beginning from Galilee after the baptism that John proclaimed: ³⁸how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him. ³⁹And we are witnesses of all that he did both in the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem. They put him to death by hanging him on a tree, ⁴⁰but God raised him on the third day and made him to appear, ⁴¹not to all the people but to us who had been chosen by God as witnesses, who ate and drank with him after he rose from the dead. ⁴²And he commanded us to preach to the people and to testify that he is the one appointed by God to be judge of the living and the dead. ⁴³To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

REFLECT

1. The apostles could have said "cross." They keep saying *tree*. What connection are they trying to make in their hearers' minds?
2. In Acts 10, the message of the tree goes for the first time to a Gentile household. Why is it good news that the curse-bearing tree is announced not just to Israel but to "every nation"?

The Great Exchange

Galatians 3:10–14

"Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree" – Christ bears the curse so that the blessing of Abraham might come to us.

¹⁰For all who rely on works of the law are under a curse; for it is written, "Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them." ¹¹Now it is evident that no one is justified before God by the law, for "The righteous shall live by faith." ¹²But the law is not of faith, rather "The one who does them shall live by them." ¹³Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us—for it is written, "Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree"— ¹⁴so that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, so that we might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

1 Peter 2:21–25

"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree" – the Shepherd who brings us home.

²¹For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps. ²²He committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth. ²³When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting

himself to him who judges justly. ²⁴He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed. ²⁵For you were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.

REFLECT

1. Paul says Jesus became a curse for us. What is the difference between Jesus being treated unjustly and Jesus being deliberately treated as cursed in our place?
2. Peter says we were healed by His wounds. Where in your life — fears, regrets, broken places — do you most need that healing this Advent?
3. The Tree of Knowledge brought a curse no one could lift. The cross — another tree — lifts the curse from anyone who will look to it. How does this reframe the bare tree in your living room?

Close in prayer. Thank Jesus for hanging on a tree so that we would not have to.

SESSION 4 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

Fruit, Restoration, and the Tree of Life

The story of trees runs all the way to Revelation, where the very tree that was barred at the beginning is open again to anyone who will come.

Beauty for Ashes

Isaiah 61:1–6

God's people will be called "oaks of righteousness, a planting of the Lord" — beauty for ashes.

¹The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me, because the Lord has anointed me to bring good news to the poor; he has sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to those who are bound; ²to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor, and the day of vengeance of our God; to comfort all who mourn; ³to grant to those who mourn in Zion—to give them a beautiful headdress instead of ashes, the oil of gladness instead of mourning, the garment of praise instead of a faint spirit; that they may be called oaks of righteousness, the planting of the Lord, that he may be glorified. ⁴They shall build up the ancient ruins; they shall raise up the former devastations; they shall repair the ruined cities, the devastations of many generations. ⁵Strangers shall stand and tend your flocks; foreigners shall be your plowmen and vinedressers; ⁶but you shall be called the priests of the Lord; they shall speak of you as the ministers of our God; you shall eat the wealth of the nations, and in their glory you shall boast.

REFLECT

1. God promises to call His people "oaks of righteousness, a planting of the Lord." What does it mean that the strength of an oak is something God gives, not something we grow?
2. "Beauty for ashes" — what part of your family's story this Advent feels like ashes that you would like to place into God's hands?

By Their Fruit You Will Know Them

Matthew 7:15-23

"Every good tree bears good fruit" — you will recognize them by their fruit.

¹⁵"Beware of false prophets, who come to you in sheep's clothing but inwardly are ravenous wolves. ¹⁶You will recognize them by their fruits. Are grapes gathered from thornbushes, or figs from thistles? ¹⁷So, every healthy tree bears good fruit, but the diseased tree bears bad fruit. ¹⁸A healthy tree cannot bear bad fruit, nor can a diseased tree bear good fruit. ¹⁹Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire. ²⁰Thus you will recognize them by their fruits. ²¹"Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven. ²²On that day many will say to me, 'Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name, and cast out demons in your name, and do many mighty works in your name?' ²³And then will I declare to them, 'I never knew you; depart from me, you workers of lawlessness.'

Matthew 12:33-37

"Either make the tree good and its fruit good, or make the tree bad" — the heart revealed.

³³"Either make the tree good and its fruit good, or make the tree bad and its fruit bad, for the tree is known by its fruit. ³⁴You brood of vipers! How can you speak good, when you are evil? For out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks. ³⁵The good person out of his good treasure brings forth good, and the evil person out of his evil treasure brings forth evil. ³⁶I tell you, on the day of judgment people will give account for every careless word they speak, ³⁷for by your words you will be justified, and by your words you will be condemned.

Luke 13:6-9

The parable of the barren fig tree — patience, judgment, and one more year of grace.

⁶And he told this parable: "A man had a fig tree planted in his vineyard, and he came seeking fruit on it and found none. ⁷And he said to the vinedresser, 'Look, for three years now I have come seeking fruit on this fig tree, and I find none. Cut it down. Why should it use up the ground?' ⁸And he answered him, 'Sir, let it alone this year also, until I dig around it and put on manure. ⁹Then if it should bear fruit next year, well and good; but if not, you can cut it down.'"

John 15:1-8

"I am the vine, you are the branches" — abiding in Christ, the living wood.

¹"I am the true vine, and my Father is the vinedresser. ²Every branch in me that does not bear fruit he takes away, and every branch that does bear fruit he prunes, that it may bear more fruit. ³Already you are clean because of the word that I have spoken to you. ⁴Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit by itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you,

unless you abide in me. ⁵I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing. ⁶If anyone does not abide in me, he is thrown away like a branch and withers; and the branches are gathered, thrown into the fire, and burned. ⁷If you abide in me, and my words abide in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you. ⁸By this my Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit and so prove to be my disciples.

REFLECT

1. Jesus is relentless about fruit. Why is fruit the test, and not effort, sincerity, or appearance?
2. The barren fig tree gets one more year. How does the patience of God in that parable shape your view of someone in your life who has not yet come to faith?
3. John 15 says the secret of fruit is *abiding*, not striving. What does that look like for you in this season?

The Tree of Life, Open Again

Revelation 2:1-7

"To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life" — the promise renewed.

¹"To the angel of the church in Ephesus write: 'The words of him who holds the seven stars in his right hand, who walks among the seven golden lampstands. ²"I know your works, your toil and your patient endurance, and how you cannot bear with those who are evil, but have tested those who call themselves apostles and are not, and found them to be false. ³I know you are enduring patiently and bearing up for my name's sake, and you have not grown weary. ⁴But I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first. ⁵Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent, and do the works you did at first.

If not, I will come to you and remove your lampstand from its place, unless you repent. ⁶Yet this you have: you hate the works of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate. ⁷He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God.'

Revelation 22:1-5

The Tree of Life restored, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, its leaves for the healing of the nations.

¹Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb ²through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations. ³No longer will there be anything accursed, but the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him. ⁴They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. ⁵And night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.

REFLECT

1. The tree barred by an angel in Genesis 3 stands wide open in Revelation 22. What happened in between to take the angel away?
2. The leaves of the tree are "for the healing of the nations." What does it mean that the end of the Bible's story is not just personal salvation, but the healing of whole peoples?
3. Look once more at the bare tree in your home. The story that began at a tree in Eden, ran through a tree at Calvary, ends at a tree in the new creation. How will you tell that story to your family this week?

Close in prayer. Thank God that the story of the tree ends with healing, not exile.



SECOND WEEK OF ADVENT

II

The Light

"But if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin."

1 JOHN 1:7

Week Two · Second Week of Advent

Do You See the Lights?

Preparation This Week

On the second Sunday of Advent, hang lights on your bare tree — white or clear lights are especially meaningful, though any colour works. Do not add ornaments yet. Let the lit tree stand alone for the week: tree and light, nothing more. The lights themselves are the message.

*T*hink about how most families decorate their tree. The lights go on first — and then, within minutes, they disappear under layers of ornaments, tinsel, and ribbon. We step back and admire the finished product, but the lights themselves are buried. They are still there, glowing behind everything else, but no one is looking at them anymore.

It is a small parable. Many of us treat the light of God in our lives the same way. We pile on activity, entertainment, comfort, ambition — even good things, important things — until the light that was supposed to be the foundation of everything becomes invisible. Not extinguished. Just covered. We have stopped seeing it.

This week, your tree will not let you do that. There are no ornaments to hide behind. There is only the bare tree from last week — and now, light. Look at it. Sit with your family in a darkened room and let the tree glow. What you are seeing is a picture of the gospel.

*"God said, 'Let there be light' — and there was light.
Before the sun. Before the stars. Before anything else
existed. Light came first."*

Light Before All Things

When God created the universe, the very first thing He made was light (Genesis 1:3). Not the sun — that came on the fourth day. Not the stars or the moon. Light itself, called into existence by the voice of God, preceding and undergirding everything that would follow. This is not a scientific puzzle to be solved. It is a theological declaration: God is the source of all light. He does not depend on anything He has made. He is the light, and *"in him is no darkness at all"* (1 John 1:5).

But darkness is real. The Bible does not pretend otherwise. Job sat in ashes and cursed the day he was born, longing for a darkness so complete that not even God would look for him (Job 3). The psalmist cried out from the pit, *"Darkness is my closest friend"* (Psalm 88:18). The people of Israel walked in literal darkness during the exile — centuries of silence, oppression, and waiting. Darkness is what the world looks like when the light is hidden.

Into that darkness, the prophets spoke. Isaiah declared, *"The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light"* (Isaiah 9:2). He promised that God would send His servant as *"a light for the nations, to open the eyes that are blind"* (Isaiah 42:6-7). And Malachi, the last prophetic voice before four hundred years of silence, ended with a promise: *"The sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings"* (Malachi 4:2).

Then the silence fell. Four centuries. No prophet. No word. No sign. And then — a baby, born at night, in a stable, in an occupied backwater of the Roman Empire. Angels appeared to shepherds in the dark, and *"the glory of the Lord shone around them"* (Luke 2:9). The light had come. Not as the world expected. Not with armies or spectacle. But as a child, wrapped in cloths, laid in a feeding trough.

John's Gospel opens not with the manger but with the meaning behind it: *"In him was life, and the life was the light of men. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it"* (John 1:4-5). This is the claim of Christmas. The light is not a metaphor. It is a person. And the darkness — all of it, every kind, from Eden's exile to your worst night — has not overcome it.

Your Tree in the Darkness

The lights on your tree this week are not decorations. They are a confession. They say: we believe that the light has come. We believe that the darkness does not win. We believe that the God who said "Let there be light" before anything else existed has sent His own Son as the true Light into the world — and that *"whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life"* (John 8:12).

But the Bible is honest about light in a way that should unsettle us. Jesus said, "*The light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light*" (John 3:19). The light is here. The question is whether we will step into it — or whether we prefer the comfort of the dark. Walking in the light means walking in truth, in confession, in fellowship (1 John 1:7). It means being seen. That is harder than it sounds.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~20 MIN

Light Before All Else

Hang the lights, then sit in the glow with the room dark and read where the Bible's whole story of light begins — before there was a sun, a moon, or a single star.

"Let There Be Light"

Genesis 1:1-5

God's first act of creation — light called into existence by His voice, before the sun, moon, or stars exist.

¹In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth. ²The earth was without form and void, and darkness was over the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters. ³And God said, "Let there be light," and there was light. ⁴And God saw that the light was good. And God separated the light from the darkness. ⁵God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And there was evening and there was morning, the first day.

Genesis 1:14-19

God creates the sun, moon, and stars on the fourth day — the lights of the sky serve a Light that was already there.

¹⁴And God said, "Let there be lights in the expanse of the heavens to separate the day from the night. And let them be for signs and for seasons, and for days and years, ¹⁵and let them be lights in the expanse of the heavens to give light upon the earth." And it was so. ¹⁶And God made the two great lights—the greater light to rule the day and the lesser light to rule the night—and the stars. ¹⁷And God set them in the expanse of the heavens to give light on the earth, ¹⁸to rule over the day and over the night, and to

separate the light from the darkness. And God saw that it was good. ¹⁹And there was evening and there was morning, the fourth day.

REFLECT

1. The first thing God made was not a star or a sun, but light itself. What is the Bible telling us about God when it makes light come *before* the things that produce it?
2. Light is the only thing God called "good" before there was anyone to see it. Why does that matter when you feel like no one is watching the small good things you are doing?
3. Look at the lights on your tree. Before any ornament, any gift, any other thing of Christmas — there is just light. How does that match the way the Bible begins?

Close in prayer. Thank God that the same God who first said "let there be light" still speaks light into our darkness.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~40 MIN

Darkness and the Cry for Light

The Bible is honest about darkness – plagues, laments, and dark nights of the soul. Before we read the promise of light, we sit with the people who longed for it.

When Darkness Falls

Exodus 10: 21-29

The plague of darkness over Egypt – three days so thick it could be felt, yet Israel had light in their dwellings.

²¹Then the Lord said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand toward heaven, that there may be darkness over the land of Egypt, a darkness to be felt." ²²So Moses stretched out his hand toward heaven, and there was pitch darkness in all the land of Egypt three days. ²³They did not see one another, nor did anyone rise from his place for three days, but all the people of Israel had light where they lived. ²⁴Then Pharaoh called Moses and said, "Go, serve the Lord; your children also may go with you; only let your flocks and your herds remain behind." ²⁵But Moses said, "You must also let us have sacrifices and burnt offerings, that we may sacrifice to the Lord our God. ²⁶Our livestock also must go with us; not a hoof shall be left behind, for we must take of them to serve the Lord our God, and we do not know with what we must serve the Lord until we arrive there." ²⁷But the Lord hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he would not let them go. ²⁸Then Pharaoh said to him, "Get away from me; take care never to see my face again, for on the day you see my face you shall die." ²⁹Moses said, "As you say! I will not see your face again."

Job 3:1-26

Job laments in darkness – a man who has lost everything and wishes the day of his birth had been swallowed by night.

¹After this Job opened his mouth and cursed the day of his birth.
²And Job said: ³"Let the day perish on which I was born, and the night that said, 'A man is conceived.' ⁴Let that day be darkness! May God above not seek it, nor light shine upon it. ⁵Let gloom and deep darkness claim it. Let clouds dwell upon it; let the blackness of the day terrify it. ⁶That night—let thick darkness seize it! Let it not rejoice among the days of the year; let it not come into the number of the months. ⁷Behold, let that night be barren; let no joyful cry enter it. ⁸Let those curse it who curse the day, who are ready to rouse up Leviathan. ⁹Let the stars of its dawn be dark; let it hope for light, but have none, nor see the eyelids of the morning, ¹⁰because it did not shut the doors of my mother's womb, nor hide trouble from my eyes. ¹¹"Why did I not die at birth, come out from the womb and expire? ¹²Why did the knees receive me? Or why the breasts, that I should nurse? ¹³For then I would have lain down and been quiet; I would have slept; then I would have been at rest, ¹⁴with kings and counselors of the earth who rebuilt ruins for themselves, ¹⁵or with princes who had gold, who filled their houses with silver. ¹⁶Or why was I not as a hidden stillborn child, as infants who never see the light? ¹⁷There the wicked cease from troubling, and there the weary are at rest. ¹⁸There the prisoners are at ease together; they hear not the voice of the taskmaster. ¹⁹The small and the great are there, and the slave is free from his master. ²⁰"Why is light given to him who is in misery, and life to the bitter in soul, ²¹who long for death, but it comes not, and dig for it more than for hidden treasures, ²²who rejoice exceedingly and are glad when they find the grave? ²³Why is light given to a man whose way is hidden, whom God has hedged in? ²⁴For my sighing comes instead of my bread, and my groanings are poured out like water. ²⁵For the thing that I fear comes upon me, and what I dread befalls me. ²⁶I am not at ease, nor am I quiet; I have no rest, but trouble comes."

Psalm 88

"Darkness is my closest friend" – the Bible's darkest psalm, a cry from someone who sees no light at all.

¹O Lord, God of my salvation, I cry out day and night before you. ²Let my prayer come before you; incline your ear to my cry! ³For my soul is full of troubles, and my life draws near to Sheol. ⁴I am counted among those who go down to the pit; I am a man who has no strength, ⁵like one set loose among the dead, like the slain that lie in the grave, like those whom you remember no more, for they are cut off from your hand. ⁶You have put me in the depths of the pit, in the regions dark and deep. ⁷Your wrath lies heavy upon me, and you overwhelm me with all your waves. ⁸You have caused my companions to shun me; you have made me a horror to them. I am shut in so that I cannot escape; ⁹my eye grows dim through sorrow. Every day I call upon you, O Lord; I spread out my hands to you. ¹⁰Do you work wonders for the dead? Do the departed rise up to praise you? ¹¹Is your steadfast love declared in the grave, or your faithfulness in Abaddon? ¹²Are your wonders known in the darkness, or your righteousness in the land of forgetfulness? ¹³But I, O Lord, cry to you; in the morning my prayer comes before you. ¹⁴O Lord, why do you cast my soul away? Why do you hide your face from me? ¹⁵Afflicted and close to death from my youth up, I suffer your terrors; I am helpless. ¹⁶Your wrath has swept over me; your dreadful assaults destroy me. ¹⁷They surround me like a flood all day long; they close in on me together. ¹⁸You have caused my beloved and my friend to shun me; my companions have become darkness.

REFLECT

1. God did not edit the darkness out of the Bible — He kept Job and Psalm 88 in. Why is it important that Scripture has space for the people who feel no light?
2. In Egypt, Israel had light in their homes while darkness covered the land. What does it mean that God can keep light burning in a household even while everything around it is dark?

A Prayer for Illumination

Psalm 27:1-6

"The Lord is my light and my salvation — whom shall I fear?"

¹The Lord is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear? The Lord is the stronghold of my life; of whom shall I be afraid? ²When evildoers assail me to eat up my flesh, my adversaries and foes, it is they who stumble and fall. ³Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear; though war arise against me, yet I will be confident. ⁴One thing have I asked of the Lord, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the Lord and to inquire in his temple. ⁵For he will hide me in his shelter in the day of trouble; he will conceal me under the cover of his tent; he will lift me high upon a rock. ⁶And now my head shall be lifted up above my enemies all around me, and I will offer in his tent sacrifices with shouts of joy; I will sing and make melody to the Lord.

Psalm 36:5-9

"In your light do we see light" — all true seeing depends on God's illumination.

⁵Your steadfast love, O Lord, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds. ⁶Your righteousness is like the mountains of God; your judgments are like the great deep; man and

beast you save, O Lord. ⁷How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings. ⁸They feast on the abundance of your house, and you give them drink from the river of your delights. ⁹For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.

Psalm 43:1-5

"Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me" – a prayer for God's light to guide the way home.

¹Vindicate me, O God, and defend my cause against an ungodly people, from the deceitful and unjust man deliver me! ²For you are the God in whom I take refuge; why have you rejected me? Why do I go about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy? ³Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me; let them bring me to your holy hill and to your dwelling! ⁴Then I will go to the altar of God, to God my exceeding joy, and I will praise you with the lyre, O God, my God. ⁵Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me? Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God.

Psalm 119:105-112

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" – Scripture as the light we walk by.

¹⁰⁵Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path. ¹⁰⁶I have sworn an oath and confirmed it, to keep your righteous rules. ¹⁰⁷I am severely afflicted; give me life, O Lord, according to your word! ¹⁰⁸Accept my freewill offerings of praise, O Lord, and teach me your rules. ¹⁰⁹I hold my life in my hand continually, but I do not forget your law. ¹¹⁰The wicked have laid a snare for me, but I do not stray from your precepts. ¹¹¹Your testimonies are my heritage forever, for they are the joy of my heart. ¹¹²I incline my heart to perform your statutes forever, to the end.

REFLECT

1. David calls the Lord his light, his salvation, and his stronghold all in one verse. What is the difference between calling God your light and merely calling Him helpful?
2. Psalm 119 says God's word is a lamp to *your feet* — enough light for the next step, not the next mile. Where is God currently giving you only enough light for the next step?

Close in prayer. Pray for someone in your life who is sitting in a darkness like Job's or Psalm 88.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~35 MIN

The Light Promised, the Light Arrives

For centuries the prophets promised dawn was coming. Then four hundred years of silence — and then a baby, born at night, in a stable.

The Promise of Dawn

Isaiah 9:1-7

"The people walking in darkness have seen a great light" — the promised Prince of Peace.

¹But there will be no gloom for her who was in anguish. In the former time he brought into contempt the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali, but in the latter time he has made glorious the way of the sea, the land beyond the Jordan, Galilee of the nations. ²The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light; those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness, on them has light shone. ³You have multiplied the nation; you have increased its joy; they rejoice before you as with joy at the harvest, as they are glad when they divide the spoil. ⁴For the yoke of his burden, and the staff for his shoulder, the rod of his oppressor, you have broken as on the day of Midian. ⁵For every boot of the tramping warrior in battle tumult and every garment rolled in blood will be burned as fuel for the fire. ⁶For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. ⁷Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end, on the throne of David and over his kingdom, to establish it and to uphold it with justice and with righteousness from this time forth and forevermore. The zeal of the Lord of hosts will do this.

Isaiah 42:5-9

"I will give you as a light for the nations, to open the eyes that are blind" — the Servant's mission.

⁵Thus says God, the Lord, who created the heavens and stretched them out, who spread out the earth and what comes from it, who gives breath to the people on it and spirit to those who walk in it: ⁶"I am the Lord; I have called you in righteousness; I will take you by the hand and keep you; I will give you as a covenant for the people, a light for the nations, ⁷to open the eyes that are blind, to bring out the prisoners from the dungeon, from the prison those who sit in darkness. ⁸I am the Lord; that is my name; my glory I give to no other, nor my praise to carved idols. ⁹Behold, the former things have come to pass, and new things I now declare; before they spring forth I tell you of them."

Isaiah 60:1-5

"Arise, shine, for your light has come, and the glory of the Lord has risen upon you."

¹Arise, shine, for your light has come, and the glory of the Lord has risen upon you. ²For behold, darkness shall cover the earth, and thick darkness the peoples; but the Lord will arise upon you, and his glory will be seen upon you. ³And nations shall come to your light, and kings to the brightness of your rising. ⁴Lift up your eyes all around, and see; they all gather together, they come to you; your sons shall come from afar, and your daughters shall be carried on the hip. ⁵Then you shall see and be radiant; your heart shall thrill and exult, because the abundance of the sea shall be turned to you, the wealth of the nations shall come to you.

Malachi 4:1-6

"The sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings" – the last promise before four centuries of silence.

¹"For behold, the day is coming, burning like an oven, when all the arrogant and all evildoers will be stubble. The day that is coming shall set them ablaze, says the Lord of hosts, so that it will leave them neither root nor branch. ²But for you who fear my name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings. You shall go out leaping like calves from the stall. ³And you shall tread down the wicked, for they will be ashes under the soles of your feet, on the day when I act, says the Lord of hosts. ⁴"Remember the law of my servant Moses, the statutes and rules that I commanded him at Horeb for all Israel. ⁵"Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes. ⁶And he will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers, lest I come and strike the land with a decree of utter destruction."

REFLECT

1. Isaiah promised "a great light" to people walking in darkness. Note that he says *walking*, not standing still. What does it look like to keep walking when you cannot see what's ahead?
2. Malachi was the last word from God for four hundred years. What might it have been like to be a faithful Israelite in that long silence – and what comfort do you draw from knowing God was not absent in it?

The Light in the Manger

John 1:1-18

"In him was life, and the life was the light of men. The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it."

¹In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. ²He was in the beginning with God. ³All things were made through him, and without him was not any thing made that was made. ⁴In him was life, and the life was the light of men. ⁵The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it. ⁶There was a man sent from God, whose name was John. ⁷He came as a witness, to bear witness about the light, that all might believe through him. ⁸He was not the light, but came to bear witness about the light. ⁹The true light, which gives light to everyone, was coming into the world. ¹⁰He was in the world, and the world was made through him, yet the world did not know him. ¹¹He came to his own, and his own people did not receive him. ¹²But to all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God, ¹³who were born, not of blood nor of the will of the flesh nor of the will of man, but of God. ¹⁴And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth. ¹⁵(John bore witness about him, and cried out, "This was he of whom I said, 'He who comes after me ranks before me, because he was before me.'") ¹⁶For from his fullness we have all received, grace upon grace. ¹⁷For the law was given through Moses; grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. ¹⁸No one has ever seen God; God the only Son, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known.

Luke 2:1-21

The birth of Jesus — the light enters the world at night, in poverty, announced to shepherds by the glory of the Lord.

¹In those days a decree went out from Caesar Augustus that all the world should be registered. ²This was the first registration

when Quirinius was governor of Syria. ³And all went to be registered, each to his own town. ⁴And Joseph also went up from Galilee, from the town of Nazareth, to Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed, who was with child. ⁶And while they were there, the time came for her to give birth. ⁷And she gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped him in swaddling cloths and laid him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn. ⁸And in the same region there were shepherds out in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And an angel of the Lord appeared to them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were filled with great fear. ¹⁰And the angel said to them, "Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people. ¹¹For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. ¹²And this will be a sign for you: you will find a baby wrapped in swaddling cloths and lying in a manger." ¹³And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying, ¹⁴"Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace among those with whom he is pleased!" ¹⁵When the angels went away from them into heaven, the shepherds said to one another, "Let us go over to Bethlehem and see this thing that has happened, which the Lord has made known to us." ¹⁶And they went with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the baby lying in a manger. ¹⁷And when they saw it, they made known the saying that had been told them concerning this child. ¹⁸And all who heard it wondered at what the shepherds told them. ¹⁹But Mary treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart. ²⁰And the shepherds returned, glorifying and praising God for all they had heard and seen, as it had been told them. ²¹And at the end of eight days, when he was circumcised, he was called Jesus, the name given by the angel before he was conceived in the womb.

REFLECT

1. John says the light shines in the darkness and the darkness *has not overcome it*. Where in your life right now do you most need to hear that the darkness has not won?
2. God announced the arrival of His Son to night-shift shepherds — not to kings or priests. What is God saying about who He is by the people He chooses to tell first?
3. Sit quietly with only your tree lights on. Read John 1:1–5 again, slowly. What do those familiar words sound like in the dark?

Close in prayer. Thank God that He did not leave us in the dark.

SESSION 4 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

The Light Embraced — and the Eternal Day

The Light has come — but a light demands a response. We close this week looking at what it means to walk in the light, and at the city where God Himself will be the light forever.

The Light You Cannot Stay Neutral About

John 8:12-20

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

¹²Again Jesus spoke to them, saying, "I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life." ¹³So the Pharisees said to him, "You are bearing witness about yourself; your testimony is not true." ¹⁴Jesus answered, "Even if I do bear witness about myself, my testimony is true, for I know where I came from and where I am going, but you do not know where I come from or where I am going. ¹⁵You judge according to the flesh; I judge no one. ¹⁶Yet even if I do judge, my judgment is true, for it is not I alone who judge, but I and the Father who sent me. ¹⁷In your Law it is written that the testimony of two people is true. ¹⁸I am the one who bears witness about myself, and the Father who sent me bears witness about me." ¹⁹They said to him therefore, "Where is your Father?" Jesus answered, "You know neither me nor my Father. If you knew me, you would know my Father also." ²⁰These words he spoke in the treasury, as he taught in the temple; but no one arrested him, because his hour had not yet come.

John 3:19–21

"The light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light" — why some turn away.

19 And this is the judgment: the light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light because their works were evil. 20 For everyone who does wicked things hates the light and does not come to the light, lest his works should be exposed. 21 But whoever does what is true comes to the light, so that it may be clearly seen that his works have been carried out in God.

REFLECT

1. Jesus does not say "I will show you light." He says, "I am the light." What is the difference between trying to find light and following the One who is light?
2. John 3 says some loved darkness because their deeds were evil. Where in your life do you find yourself preferring not to be seen — and what is the gospel's invitation to bring it into the light?

Walking as Children of Light

Matthew 5:14–16

"You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden" — Jesus tells His followers they carry the light.

14 "You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden. 15 Nor do people light a lamp and put it under a basket, but on a stand, and it gives light to all in the house. 16 In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven.

Ephesians 5:8-14

"You were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light."

⁸for at one time you were darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light ⁹(for the fruit of light is found in all that is good and right and true), ¹⁰and try to discern what is pleasing to the Lord. ¹¹Take no part in the unfruitful works of darkness, but instead expose them. ¹²For it is shameful even to speak of the things that they do in secret. ¹³But when anything is exposed by the light, it becomes visible, ¹⁴for anything that becomes visible is light. Therefore it says, "Awake, O sleeper, and arise from the dead, and Christ will shine on you."

1 John 1:5-10

"God is light, and in him is no darkness at all" – walking in the light means walking in truth and fellowship.

⁵This is the message we have heard from him and proclaim to you, that God is light, and in him is no darkness at all. ⁶If we say we have fellowship with him while we walk in darkness, we lie and do not practice the truth. ⁷But if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin. ⁸If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. ⁹If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness. ¹⁰If we say we have not sinned, we make him a liar, and his word is not in us.

REFLECT

1. Jesus says "you are the light of the world" — present tense, before they had done anything. What does that change about how you understand your role at home, at work, or at school?
2. 1 John says walking in the light means honest fellowship and confession, not flawlessness. What hidden thing might it be time to bring into the light this Advent?

No More Night

Revelation 21:22-27

"The city has no need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light" — the new Jerusalem.

²²And I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb. ²³And the city has no need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light, and its lamp is the Lamb. ²⁴By its light will the nations walk, and the kings of the earth will bring their glory into it, ²⁵and its gates will never be shut by day—and there will be no night there. ²⁶They will bring into it the glory and the honor of the nations. ²⁷But nothing unclean will ever enter it, nor anyone who does what is detestable or false, but only those who are written in the Lamb's book of life.

Revelation 22:1-5

"Night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light" — the story ends where it began.

¹Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb ²through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing

of the nations. ³No longer will there be anything accursed, but the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him. ⁴They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. ⁵And night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.

REFLECT

1. The Bible begins with God saying "let there be light" and ends with God Himself *being* the light. What is gained by reading those two scenes together?
2. "Night will be no more." If you took that promise seriously this week, what fear or grief would loosen its grip on you?
3. Look once more at the tree, lit and bare, no ornaments yet. The lights point to the Light. How will you keep seeing the lights — really seeing them — when the ornaments go on next week?

Close in prayer. Thank God for the day that is coming when the lights on the tree will no longer be needed.



THIRD WEEK OF ADVENT

III

Prophecy & Heritage

*"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is
the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may
have life in his name."*

JOHN 20:31

Week Three · Third Week of Advent

The Forgotten Ornaments

Preparation This Week

On the third Sunday of Advent, decorate your lit tree together. Hang the pretty ornaments and the meaningful ones alike. But when you come to the ones that carry a story — heirlooms, symbols of faith, tokens of God's faithfulness in your family — pause and **tell that story aloud**. What does it represent? Who gave it? What has God done? Each year, add more meaningful ornaments. **Leave the very top of the tree bare** — that moment belongs to next week.

*E*very family has a box of Christmas ornaments. Most of them have been hanging on trees for years — some for decades. But ask anyone what a particular ornament means, where it came from, or why it matters, and you will usually get a shrug. The stories have been lost. The ornaments still come out every December, but they have become weightless — familiar objects with forgotten meanings.

The Bible warns that faith can go the same way. Children can grow up hearing the stories of Scripture — handling them, feeling their familiar weight, even placing them in the right order — without ever grasping the story behind the story. They know that Jesus was born in Bethlehem. But do they know that the prophet Micah named that town seven hundred years before it happened (Micah 5:2)? They know

that Jesus died on a cross. But do they know that David described the crucifixion in Psalm 22 a thousand years before crucifixion was invented? They know the nativity. But do they know why it matters — to them, here, now?

This is why God has always commanded His people to do two things: *remember* and *pass it on*.

"Prophecy is memory made certain in advance. Every ornament on the tree of faith was placed there by the hand of God — centuries before Christmas morning."

Stones, Feasts, and Stories

When Israel crossed the Jordan into the Promised Land, God told Joshua to take twelve stones from the riverbed and pile them on the bank. Why? *"When your children ask, 'What do these stones mean?' — tell them"* (Joshua 4:6-7). The stones had no value in themselves. Their purpose was to provoke a question, so that the answer — God's faithfulness — would be spoken aloud to the next generation.

The Passover served the same purpose. God built the question into the ceremony itself: *"When your children say to you, 'What do you mean by this service?' — you shall say, 'It is the sacrifice of the Lord's Passover'"* (Exodus 12:26-27). Every year, the family was to retell the story of deliverance from Egypt. Moses charged the people directly: *"Teach them diligently to your children, and talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down,*

and when you rise" (Deuteronomy 6:7). The faith was not meant to be stored in a chest and brought out once a year. It was meant to be spoken — constantly, naturally, in the rhythm of daily life.

And running alongside this thread of remembrance is the thread of prophecy. God did not only tell His people what He had done. He told them what He was going to do — with a precision that still astonishes. The offspring of the woman would crush the serpent's head (Genesis 3:15). The blessing would come through Abraham's line (Genesis 12:3). The king would sit on David's throne forever (2 Samuel 7:13). A virgin would conceive (Isaiah 7:14). The ruler would come from Bethlehem (Micah 5:2). The servant would be pierced for our transgressions (Isaiah 53:5). Century after century, the picture sharpened until there was only one face it could be.

When Prophecy Became a Person

One Sabbath in Nazareth, Jesus stood up in the synagogue, unrolled the scroll of Isaiah, and read: *"The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor"* (Luke 4:18, quoting Isaiah 61:1). He rolled the scroll back up, sat down, and said seven words that changed everything: *"Today this Scripture is fulfilled in your hearing"* (Luke 4:21).

The people who had known Him since childhood were furious. They tried to throw Him off a cliff (Luke 4:28–29). This is the strange danger of familiarity — the same danger that turns meaningful ornaments into forgotten decorations. The prophecies were right in front of them, being fulfilled before their eyes, and they could not see it.

After the resurrection, on the road to Emmaus, Jesus walked two disciples through the entire Old Testament — Moses, the Prophets, the Psalms — and showed them that *every thread led to Him* (Luke 24:27). Their hearts burned within them (Luke 24:32). They had read these Scriptures their whole lives. But they had never seen the story behind the story.

Your Tree as a Memorial

As you hang ornaments on the tree, you are doing what Joshua did with his stones — at least with some of them. Not every ornament needs to carry weight. Many are simply pretty, and that is fine. But scattered among them are the ones that do carry a story: a grandparent's ornament and the weight of generational faith; a wooden cross and the whole gospel; an ornament made by a child's hands. Those are the memorial stones.

With those, resist the temptation to rush. Hang each one slowly. Speak its meaning aloud. Ask the children what they think it represents. Each year, add more — an answered prayer, a milestone, a season of grace. Over time, the tree itself becomes a map of your family's walk with God.

And as the tree fills up, notice what is missing. The top is bare. The tree is not complete yet. The greatest gift has not arrived. That is the tension of Advent — the ache of waiting that makes Christmas morning what it is.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~35 MIN

The Command to Remember

As you hang each ornament, you are doing what God's people have always done — building a memorial that provokes a question, so that the answer can be told.

Stones, Feasts, and Stories

Genesis 28:10–22

Jacob's ladder — he sets up a stone as a memorial and says, "Surely the Lord is in this place, and I did not know it."

¹⁰Jacob left Beersheba and went toward Haran. ¹¹And he came to a certain place and stayed there that night, because the sun had set. Taking one of the stones of the place, he put it under his head and lay down in that place to sleep. ¹²And he dreamed, and behold, there was a ladder set up on the earth, and the top of it reached to heaven. And behold, the angels of God were ascending and descending on it! ¹³And behold, the Lord stood above it and said, "I am the Lord, the God of Abraham your father and the God of Isaac. The land on which you lie I will give to you and to your offspring. ¹⁴Your offspring shall be like the dust of the earth, and you shall spread abroad to the west and to the east and to the north and to the south, and in you and your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed. ¹⁵Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go, and will bring you back to this land. For I will not leave you until I have done what I have promised you." ¹⁶Then Jacob awoke from his sleep and said, "Surely the Lord is in this place, and I did not know it." ¹⁷And he was afraid and said, "How awesome is this place! This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven." ¹⁸So early in the morning Jacob took the stone that he had put under his head and set it up for a pillar and poured oil on the top of it.

¹⁹He called the name of that place Bethel, but the name of the city was Luz at the first. ²⁰Then Jacob made a vow, saying, "If God will be with me and will keep me in this way that I go, and will give me bread to eat and clothing to wear, ²¹so that I come again to my father's house in peace, then the Lord shall be my God, ²²and this stone, which I have set up for a pillar, shall be God's house. And of all that you give me I will give a full tenth to you."

Exodus 12:1-14

The Passover instituted – "This day shall be for you a memorial day... throughout your generations."

¹The Lord said to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, ²"This month shall be for you the beginning of months. It shall be the first month of the year for you. ³Tell all the congregation of Israel that on the tenth day of this month every man shall take a lamb according to their fathers' houses, a lamb for a household. ⁴And if the household is too small for a lamb, then he and his nearest neighbor shall take according to the number of persons; according to what each can eat you shall make your count for the lamb. ⁵Your lamb shall be without blemish, a male a year old. You may take it from the sheep or from the goats, ⁶and you shall keep it until the fourteenth day of this month, when the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill their lambs at twilight. ⁷"Then they shall take some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of the houses in which they eat it. ⁸They shall eat the flesh that night, roasted on the fire; with unleavened bread and bitter herbs they shall eat it. ⁹Do not eat any of it raw or boiled in water, but roasted, its head with its legs and its inner parts. ¹⁰And you shall let none of it remain until the morning; anything that remains until the morning you shall burn. ¹¹In this manner you shall eat it: with your belt fastened, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand. And you shall eat it in haste. It is the Lord's Passover. ¹²For I will pass through the land of Egypt that night, and I will strike all the firstborn in

the land of Egypt, both man and beast; and on all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments: I am the Lord. ¹³The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you, when I strike the land of Egypt. ¹⁴"This day shall be for you a memorial day, and you shall keep it as a feast to the Lord; throughout your generations, as a statute forever, you shall keep it as a feast."

Joshua 4:1-9

Twelve stones from the Jordan – "When your children ask, 'What do these stones mean?' – tell them..."

¹When all the nation had finished passing over the Jordan, the Lord said to Joshua, ²"Take twelve men from the people, from each tribe a man, ³and command them, saying, 'Take twelve stones from here out of the midst of the Jordan, from the very place where the priests' feet stood firmly, and bring them over with you and lay them down in the place where you lodge to-night.'" ⁴Then Joshua called the twelve men from the people of Israel, whom he had appointed, a man from each tribe. ⁵And Joshua said to them, "Pass on before the ark of the Lord your God into the midst of the Jordan, and take up each of you a stone upon his shoulder, according to the number of the tribes of the people of Israel, ⁶that this may be a sign among you. When your children ask in time to come, 'What do those stones mean to you?' ⁷then you shall tell them that the waters of the Jordan were cut off before the ark of the covenant of the Lord. When it passed over the Jordan, the waters of the Jordan were cut off. So these stones shall be to the people of Israel a memorial forever." ⁸And the people of Israel did just as Joshua commanded and took up twelve stones out of the midst of the Jordan, according to the number of the tribes of the people of Israel, just as the Lord told Joshua. And they carried them over with them to the place where they lodged and laid them down there. ⁹And Joshua set up twelve stones in the midst of the Jordan, in the place where the

feet of the priests bearing the ark of the covenant had stood; and they are there to this day.

REFLECT

1. God could have written His acts on the sky for all to see. Instead He told His people to pile up stones, eat a meal, and explain it to their children. Why does He insist that remembering happen at the family table?
2. Jacob said, "Surely the Lord is in this place, and I did not know it." Where in your family's recent story did God meet you that you only saw afterward?

Pass It On

Deuteronomy 4:1-15

"Make them known to your children and your children's children" – Moses' charge to Israel before they enter the land.

¹"And now, O Israel, listen to the statutes and the rules that I am teaching you, and do them, that you may live, and go in and take possession of the land that the Lord, the God of your fathers, is giving you. ²You shall not add to the word that I command you, nor take from it, that you may keep the commandments of the Lord your God that I command you. ³Your eyes have seen what the Lord did at Baal-peor, for the Lord your God destroyed from among you all the men who followed the Baal of Peor. ⁴But you who held fast to the Lord your God are all alive today. ⁵See, I have taught you statutes and rules, as the Lord my God commanded me, that you should do them in the land that you are entering to take possession of it. ⁶Keep them and do them, for that will be your wisdom and your understanding in the sight of the peoples, who, when they hear all these statutes, will say, 'Surely this great nation is a wise and understanding people.' ⁷For what great nation is there that has a god so near to it as the Lord

our God is to us, whenever we call upon him? ⁸And what great nation is there, that has statutes and rules so righteous as all this law that I set before you today? ⁹"Only take care, and keep your soul diligently, lest you forget the things that your eyes have seen, and lest they depart from your heart all the days of your life. Make them known to your children and your children's children-- ¹⁰how on the day that you stood before the Lord your God at Horeb, the Lord said to me, 'Gather the people to me, that I may let them hear my words, so that they may learn to fear me all the days that they live on the earth, and that they may teach their children so.' ¹¹And you came near and stood at the foot of the mountain, while the mountain burned with fire to the heart of heaven, wrapped in darkness, cloud, and gloom. ¹²Then the Lord spoke to you out of the midst of the fire. You heard the sound of words, but saw no form; there was only a voice. ¹³And he declared to you his covenant, which he commanded you to perform, that is, the Ten Commandments, and he wrote them on two tablets of stone. ¹⁴And the Lord commanded me at that time to teach you statutes and rules, that you might do them in the land that you are going over to possess. ¹⁵"Therefore watch yourselves very carefully. Since you saw no form on the day that the Lord spoke to you at Horeb out of the midst of the fire,

Deuteronomy 6:4-9

"Teach them diligently to your children, and talk of them when you sit in your house" – the Shema.

⁴"Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one. ⁵You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might. ⁶And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. ⁷You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise. ⁸You shall bind them as a sign on your hand, and they shall be as frontlets between your eyes. ⁹You shall write them on the doorposts of your house and on your gates.

REFLECT

1. The Shema says to talk of God's words "when you sit, when you walk, when you lie down, when you rise." This is not a programme — it's a rhythm. Where in your family's daily rhythm could God's story more naturally find a voice?
2. Look at the ornaments going on the tree. Pick one with a story behind it and tell that story now. Why is that small act of telling a kind of obedience?

Close in prayer. Ask God to make your home a place where His story is constantly retold.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

Prophecy Spoken – The Promise Takes Shape

From a single line in Eden to a king on David's throne, God's promise of a Rescuer narrows step by step over hundreds of years.

A Promise From the Beginning

Genesis 3:15

The first prophecy – the offspring of the woman will crush the serpent's head. The rescue is promised before the exile begins.

¹⁵I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.

Genesis 12:1-3

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed" – God's covenant with Abraham narrows the promise to one line.

¹Now the Lord said to Abram, "Go from your country and your kindred and your father's house to the land that I will show you.

²And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you and make your name great, so that you will be a blessing. ³I will bless those who bless you, and him who dishonors you I will curse, and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

2 Samuel 7:12-16

"Your throne shall be established forever" – God promises David a kingdom that will never end.

¹²When your days are fulfilled and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come from your body, and I will establish his kingdom. ¹³He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. ¹⁴I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son. When he commits iniquity, I will discipline him with the rod of

men, with the stripes of the sons of men, ¹⁵but my steadfast love will not depart from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away from before you. ¹⁶And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.

REFLECT

1. Before the gates of Eden close, God already promises a Rescuer. What does this tell you about the timing of God's grace toward you when you have failed?
2. Watch the promise narrow: from "the offspring of the woman" (everyone), to "Abraham's family" (one nation), to "David's throne" (one royal line). Why does God reveal the gospel slowly across generations rather than all at once?

The Picture Sharpens

Isaiah 7:14

"The virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel" — God with us.

¹⁴Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.

Isaiah 11:1-10

"A shoot from the stump of Jesse" — when the royal line looks dead, a branch will grow.

¹There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit. ²And the Spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord. ³And his delight shall be in the fear of the Lord. He shall not judge by what his eyes see, or decide disputes by what

his ears hear, ⁴but with righteousness he shall judge the poor, and decide with equity for the meek of the earth; and he shall strike the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips he shall kill the wicked. ⁵Righteousness shall be the belt of his waist, and faithfulness the belt of his loins. ⁶The wolf shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the young goat, and the calf and the lion and the fattened calf together; and a little child shall lead them. ⁷The cow and the bear shall graze; their young shall lie down together; and the lion shall eat straw like the ox. ⁸The nursing child shall play over the hole of the cobra, and the weaned child shall put his hand on the adder's den. ⁹They shall not hurt or destroy in all my holy mountain; for the earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord as the waters cover the sea. ¹⁰In that day the root of Jesse, who shall stand as a signal for the peoples—of him shall the nations inquire, and his resting place shall be glorious.

REFLECT

1. "Immanuel" means "God with us." Why is "with-ness" — not rescue, not strength, not provision — the heart of God's promise?
2. Isaiah pictures David's line as a stump — cut down, finished. And then a shoot grows from it. Where in your family's life does something feel like a stump you have written off, that God may yet grow something out of?

Down to the Detail

Micah 5:1–5

"But you, O Bethlehem... from you shall come forth one who is to be ruler in Israel" — the town named centuries beforehand.

¹Now muster your troops, O daughter of troops; siege is laid against us; with a rod they strike the judge of Israel on the cheek.

²But you, O Bethlehem Ephrathah, who are too little to be among the clans of Judah, from you shall come forth for me one who is to be ruler in Israel, whose coming forth is from of old, from ancient days. ³Therefore he shall give them up until the time when she who is in labor has given birth; then the rest of his brothers shall return to the people of Israel. ⁴And he shall stand and shepherd his flock in the strength of the Lord, in the majesty of the name of the Lord his God. And they shall dwell secure, for now he shall be great to the ends of the earth. ⁵And he shall be their peace. When the Assyrian comes into our land and treads in our palaces, then we will raise against him seven shepherds and eight princes of men.

Isaiah 53

The Suffering Servant — "He was pierced for our transgressions, crushed for our iniquities." Written 700 years before Calvary.

¹Who has believed what he has heard from us? And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed? ²For he grew up before him like a young plant, and like a root out of dry ground; he had no form or majesty that we should look at him, and no beauty that we should desire him. ³He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief; and as one from whom men hide their faces he was despised, and we esteemed him not. ⁴Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. ⁵But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. ⁶All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all. ⁷He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth; like a lamb that is led to the slaughter, and like a sheep that before its shearers is silent, so he opened not his mouth. ⁸By oppression and judgment he was taken away; and as for his generation, who considered that he was cut off out of the land of the living,

stricken for the transgression of my people? ⁹And they made his grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, although he had done no violence, and there was no deceit in his mouth. ¹⁰Yet it was the will of the Lord to crush him; he has put him to grief; when his soul makes an offering for guilt, he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days; the will of the Lord shall prosper in his hand. ¹¹Out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied; by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities. ¹²Therefore I will divide him a portion with the many, and he shall divide the spoil with the strong, because he poured out his soul to death and was numbered with the transgressors; yet he bore the sin of many, and makes intercession for the transgressors.

REFLECT

1. Micah names Bethlehem 700 years before Jesus is born there. Why does God so often build in details that can only be appreciated in hindsight?
2. Isaiah 53 describes the cross long before there was a cross – the piercing, the crushing, the silence, the burial with the rich. As you read it aloud, what part of the description lands hardest for you?

Close in prayer. Thank God that He keeps promises across centuries – and across generations.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~40 MIN

The Cross Foretold – and "Today Fulfilled"

The picture sharpens to its most unmistakable point: the cross itself, described centuries before it happened – and the Sunday in Nazareth when Jesus rolled up the scroll and said, "Today this Scripture is fulfilled."

The Cross, Foretold

Zechariah 12:10–13:9

"They shall look on me, on him whom they have pierced, and they shall mourn" – a prophecy of the cross and of repentance.

¹⁰"And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy, so that, when they look on me, on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child, and weep bitterly over him, as one weeps over a firstborn. ¹¹On that day the mourning in Jerusalem will be as great as the mourning for Hadad-rimmon in the plain of Megiddo. ¹²The land shall mourn, each family by itself: the family of the house of David by itself, and their wives by themselves; the family of the house of Nathan by itself, and their wives by themselves; ¹³the family of the house of Levi by itself, and their wives by themselves; the family of the Shimeites by itself, and their wives by themselves; ¹⁴and all the families that are left, each by itself, and their wives by themselves. ^{13:1}On that day there shall be a fountain opened for the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, to cleanse them from sin and uncleanness. ²And on that day, declares the Lord of hosts, I will cut off the names of the idols from the land, so that they shall be remembered no more. And also I will remove from the land the prophets and the spirit of uncleanness. ³And if anyone again prophesies, his father and mother who bore him will say to him, "You shall not live, for you speak lies in the name of

the Lord.' And his father and mother who bore him shall pierce him through when he prophesies. ⁴On that day every prophet will be ashamed of his vision when he prophesies. He will not put on a hairy cloak in order to deceive, ⁵but he will say, 'I am no prophet, I am a worker of the soil, for a man sold me in my youth.' ⁶And if one asks him, 'What are these wounds on your back?' he will say, 'The wounds I received in the house of my friends.' ⁷Awake, O sword, against my shepherd, against the man who stands next to me," declares the Lord of hosts. "Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered; I will turn my hand against the little ones. ⁸In the whole land, declares the Lord, two thirds shall be cut off and perish, and one third shall be left alive. ⁹And I will put this third into the fire, and refine them as one refines silver, and test them as gold is tested. They will call upon my name, and I will answer them. I will say, 'They are my people'; and they will say, 'The Lord is my God.'"

Psalm 22:1-18

"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" – David writes the words Jesus will speak from the cross, a thousand years early.

¹My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me, from the words of my groaning? ²O my God, I cry by day, but you do not answer, and by night, but I find no rest. ³Yet you are holy, enthroned on the praises of Israel. ⁴In you our fathers trusted; they trusted, and you delivered them. ⁵To you they cried and were rescued; in you they trusted and were not put to shame. ⁶But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people. ⁷All who see me mock me; they make mouths at me; they wag their heads; ⁸"He trusts in the Lord; let him deliver him; let him rescue him, for he delights in him!" ⁹Yet you are he who took me from the womb; you made me trust you at my mother's breasts. ¹⁰On you was I cast from my birth, and from my mother's womb you have been my God. ¹¹Be not far from me, for trouble is near, and there is none to help. ¹²Many bulls encompass me; strong bulls of Bashan

surround me; ¹³they open wide their mouths at me, like a ravening and roaring lion. ¹⁴I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint; my heart is like wax; it is melted within my breast; ¹⁵my strength is dried up like a potsherd, and my tongue sticks to my jaws; you lay me in the dust of death. ¹⁶For dogs encompass me; a company of evildoers encircles me; they have pierced my hands and feet— ¹⁷I can count all my bones—they stare and gloat over me; ¹⁸they divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots.

REFLECT

1. Zechariah pictures God's people one day "looking on Him whom they have pierced" — and mourning. What does it mean to grieve over what our sin cost Him, even now?
2. David wrote Psalm 22 long before crucifixion existed. Read it again, slowly. What does it do to your view of Scripture that the prayer of a dying king matched, line by line, the prayer of a dying Saviour?

"Today This Scripture Is Fulfilled"

Matthew 1:18–25

*"All this took place to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet"
— Matthew shows how Jesus' birth fulfills Isaiah.*

¹⁸Now the birth of Jesus Christ took place in this way. When his mother Mary had been betrothed to Joseph, before they came together she was found to be with child from the Holy Spirit. ¹⁹And her husband Joseph, being a just man and unwilling to put her to shame, resolved to divorce her quietly. ²⁰But as he considered these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, "Joseph, son of David, do not fear to take Mary as your wife, for that which is conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit. ²¹She will bear a son, and you shall call his name Je-

sus, for he will save his people from their sins." ²²All this took place to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet: ²³"Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and they shall call his name Immanuel" (which means, God with us). ²⁴When Joseph woke from sleep, he did as the angel of the Lord commanded him: he took his wife, ²⁵but knew her not until she had given birth to a son. And he called his name Jesus.

Luke 4:14-30

Jesus reads from Isaiah in the synagogue and declares: "Today this Scripture is fulfilled in your hearing."

¹⁴And Jesus returned in the power of the Spirit to Galilee, and a report about him went out through all the surrounding country. ¹⁵And he taught in their synagogues, being glorified by all. ¹⁶And he came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up. And as was his custom, he went to the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and he stood up to read. ¹⁷And the scroll of the prophet Isaiah was given to him. He unrolled the scroll and found the place where it was written, ¹⁸"The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, ¹⁹to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor." ²⁰And he rolled up the scroll and gave it back to the attendant and sat down. And the eyes of all in the synagogue were fixed on him. ²¹And he began to say to them, "Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing." ²²And all spoke well of him and marveled at the gracious words that were coming from his mouth. And they said, "Is not this Joseph's son?" ²³And he said to them, "Doubtless you will quote to me this proverb, 'Physician, heal yourself.' What we have heard you did at Capernaum, do here in your hometown as well." ²⁴And he said, "Truly, I say to you, no prophet is acceptable in his hometown. ²⁵But in truth, I tell you, there were many widows in Israel in the days of Elijah, when the heavens were shut up three years and six months, and a great famine came over all the land, ²⁶and Elijah

was sent to none of them but only to Zarephath, in the land of Sidon, to a woman who was a widow. ²⁷And there were many lepers in Israel in the time of the prophet Elisha, and none of them was cleansed, but only Naaman the Syrian. ²⁸When they heard these things, all in the synagogue were filled with wrath. ²⁹And they rose up and drove him out of the town and brought him to the brow of the hill on which their town was built, so that they could throw him down the cliff. ³⁰But passing through their midst, he went away.

Luke 24:25-27

On the road to Emmaus, the risen Jesus opens all the Scriptures and shows how everything pointed to Him.

²⁵And he said to them, "O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken! ²⁶Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?" ²⁷And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself.

John 20:30-31

"These are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life."

³⁰Now Jesus did many other signs in the presence of the disciples, which are not written in this book; ³¹but these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name.

REFLECT

1. The people of Nazareth had known Jesus since childhood. They knew the prophecies. They were furious when He said the prophecies pointed to Him. Why does familiarity sometimes make it harder to see what God is doing?
2. On the Emmaus road, two grieving disciples needed Jesus to walk them through the whole Old Testament before they could see Him. Where in your own life do you need God to slow down and walk you through the story again?
3. John says "these are written so that you may believe." The whole point of the gospels is not information – it is faith. What is one place this Advent where you are being asked to move from knowing about Jesus to trusting Him?

Close in prayer. Thank God that He keeps every promise.

SESSION 4 · WEEKDAY ~30 MIN

Forgetting, and the Heritage That Endures

Memory is fragile. Faith can be lost in a single generation if it isn't passed on. We end the week with the warnings — and the picture of a heritage that reaches every nation on earth.

When the Story Stops Being Told

Judges 2:6–15

"There arose another generation after them who did not know the Lord" — what happens when the story is not passed on.

⁶When Joshua dismissed the people, the people of Israel went each to his inheritance to take possession of the land. ⁷And the people served the Lord all the days of Joshua, and all the days of the elders who outlived Joshua, who had seen all the great work that the Lord had done for Israel. ⁸And Joshua the son of Nun, the servant of the Lord, died at the age of 110 years. ⁹And they buried him within the boundaries of his inheritance in Timnath-heres, in the hill country of Ephraim, north of the mountain of Gaash. ¹⁰And all that generation also were gathered to their fathers. And there arose another generation after them who did not know the Lord or the work that he had done for Israel. ¹¹And the people of Israel did what was evil in the sight of the Lord and served the Baals. ¹²And they abandoned the Lord, the God of their fathers, who had brought them out of the land of Egypt. They went after other gods, from among the gods of the peoples who were around them, and bowed down to them. And they provoked the Lord to anger. ¹³They abandoned the Lord and served the Baals and the Ashtaroth. ¹⁴So the anger of the Lord was kindled against Israel, and he gave them over to plunderers, who plundered them. And he sold them into the hand of their surrounding enemies, so that they could no longer withstand their enemies. ¹⁵Whenever they marched out, the hand of the

Lord was against them for harm, as the Lord had warned, and as the Lord had sworn to them. And they were in terrible distress.

Hebrews 2:1-4

"We must pay much closer attention to what we have heard, lest we drift away from it."

¹Therefore we must pay much closer attention to what we have heard, lest we drift away from it. ²For since the message declared by angels proved to be reliable, and every transgression or disobedience received a just retribution, ³how shall we escape if we neglect such a great salvation? It was declared at first by the Lord, and it was attested to us by those who heard, ⁴while God also bore witness by signs and wonders and various miracles and by gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to his will.

Revelation 3:14-22

"You are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold" – the church that thought it had everything but had lost its fire.

¹⁴"And to the angel of the church in Laodicea write: 'The words of the Amen, the faithful and true witness, the beginning of God's creation. ¹⁵'"I know your works: you are neither cold nor hot. Would that you were either cold or hot! ¹⁶So, because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of my mouth. ¹⁷For you say, "I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing," not realizing that you are wretched, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked. ¹⁸I counsel you to buy from me gold refined by fire, so that you may be rich, and white garments so that you may clothe yourself and the shame of your nakedness may not be seen, and salve to anoint your eyes, so that you may see. ¹⁹Those whom I love, I reprove and discipline, so be zealous and repent. ²⁰Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me. ²¹The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my

Father on his throne. ²²He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches."

REFLECT

1. Judges says a generation arose that "did not know the Lord." It only took one. What part of the story most needs to be deliberately told to the children at your table this season?
2. Hebrews warns that we don't usually *reject* the gospel — we *drift* from it. What are the small drifts you can already see in your own walk this year?
3. Laodicea was a wealthy church that thought it lacked nothing. Where does comfort, in your home, threaten to dull your hunger for God?

A Faith That Outlives Us

Psalm 78:1-8

"We will tell the coming generation the glorious deeds of the Lord" — so that they would set their hope in God.

¹Give ear, O my people, to my teaching; incline your ears to the words of my mouth! ²I will open my mouth in a parable; I will utter dark sayings from of old, ³things that we have heard and known, that our fathers have told us. ⁴We will not hide them from their children, but tell to the coming generation the glorious deeds of the Lord, and his might, and the wonders that he has done. ⁵He established a testimony in Jacob and appointed a law in Israel, which he commanded our fathers to teach to their children, ⁶that the next generation might know them, the children yet unborn, and arise and tell them to their children, ⁷so that they should set their hope in God and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments; ⁸and that they should not be like their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation, a gen-

eration whose heart was not steadfast, whose spirit was not faithful to God.

2 Timothy 1:3-7

Paul remembers Timothy's faith – "a faith that dwelt first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice."

³I thank God whom I serve, as did my ancestors, with a clear conscience, as I remember you constantly in my prayers night and day. ⁴As I remember your tears, I long to see you, that I may be filled with joy. ⁵I am reminded of your sincere faith, a faith that dwelt first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice and now, I am sure, dwells in you as well. ⁶For this reason I remind you to fan into flame the gift of God, which is in you through the laying on of my hands, ⁷for God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control.

Isaiah 60:1-5

"Arise, shine, for your light has come" – the glory of the Lord rises over His people and draws the nations.

¹Arise, shine, for your light has come, and the glory of the Lord has risen upon you. ²For behold, darkness shall cover the earth, and thick darkness the peoples; but the Lord will arise upon you, and his glory will be seen upon you. ³And nations shall come to your light, and kings to the brightness of your rising. ⁴Lift up your eyes all around, and see; they all gather together, they come to you; your sons shall come from afar, and your daughters shall be carried on the hip. ⁵Then you shall see and be radiant; your heart shall thrill and exult, because the abundance of the sea shall be turned to you, the wealth of the nations shall come to you.

Revelation 5:9-10

"You ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" — the heritage reaches every family on earth.

⁹And they sang a new song, saying, "Worthy are you to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation, ¹⁰and you have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they shall reign on the earth."

REFLECT

1. Paul thanks God for a faith that came down to Timothy through his grandmother and mother. Who are the Lois and Eunice figures in your family — the ones whose faith you stand on?
2. Revelation 5 says the song of the redeemed includes every tribe, language, and nation. How does that picture stretch your sense of what kind of "heritage" your family is being grafted into?
3. Look at the tree, full of ornaments now. The top is still bare. What is missing — and what does it mean that the most important thing is still to come?

Close in prayer. Thank God for the people who passed the faith to you. Ask Him to make your family a faithful link in the chain.

CHRISTMAS WEEK

IV

The Gift & the Prize

*"For by him all things were created: things in heaven and
on earth, visible and invisible... all things were created by
him and for him."*

COLOSSIANS 1:16

Week Four · Christmas Week

Look at Your Tree

Preparation This Week

On the fourth Sunday of Advent, place something meaningful at the very top of the tree — ideally a cross. A star or an angel may also be used, but a cross makes the theology explicit. Surround the tree with your gifts. Then on Christmas morning, **gather your family for worship before opening any presents** — read Scripture, sing a hymn, and pray together.

Step back and look at what has been built over the last four weeks.

In the first week, you brought a bare tree into your home and left it standing alone — stripped and unadorned, like the cross it was always pointing to. You read how God has been telling His story through trees from the very beginning: the Tree of Life in Eden, the tree of the curse, the tree at Calvary, the tree restored in the city of God.

In the second week, you hung lights on the bare branches and sat in the glow. You traced the thread of light through the whole Bible — from God's first creative act, through the darkness of exile and lament, through the prophets' promise that dawn was coming, to the night when the true Light entered the world as a baby.

In the third week, you hung ornaments — each one a memorial, a stone of remembrance. You told the stories. You traced the thread of prophecy from a vague promise in a garden to a specific baby in a specific town, and you saw how every detail was fulfilled.

Now, in the fourth week, the tree is complete. A cross sits at the top. Gifts are gathered beneath. And the question that has been building all Advent long finally arrives: *What is the gift — and will you receive it?*

"Every gift under the tree points to a gift that cannot be wrapped. Every light on the tree points to a Light that cannot be extinguished. The tree itself points to the cross — and the cross points to an empty tomb."

The Gift You Cannot Earn

The Bible is relentlessly clear about this: salvation is a gift. You cannot earn it, purchase it, or achieve it. Paul wrote it as plainly as words allow: *"The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord"* (Romans 6:23). And again: *"By grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God"* (Ephesians 2:8).

This is what makes Christmas different from every other holiday. It is not a celebration of something humanity accomplished. It is a celebration of something God gave — at unimaginable cost to Himself. Paul described it this way: though

Jesus was in the form of God, He did not grasp at equality with God, but *"emptied himself,"* taking the form of a servant, being born in human likeness. He humbled Himself to the point of death — death on a cross (Philippians 2:6–8). Death on a tree.

The baby in the manger is the Creator of the universe. The one wrapped in cloths is the one who holds all things together. Colossians says it directly: *"By him all things were created, in heaven and on earth... all things were created through him and for him"* (Colossians 1:16). The gift is not merely a good teacher or a moral example. The gift is God Himself, entering His own creation, taking on the frailty and suffering of the world He made, in order to rescue the people He loves.

The Question Christmas Asks

But a gift must be received. And this is where Christmas becomes personal.

John wrote, *"Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life"* (1 John 5:12). There is no middle ground. The gift is offered freely, but it demands a response. You can admire it from a distance. You can appreciate the story. You can enjoy the season. But none of that is the same as receiving the gift.

Look at the people in the Christmas story. Mary said yes — though it would cost her everything she had planned (Luke 1:38). The shepherds left their flocks in the middle of the night and went immediately (Luke 2:15–16). The Magi travelled for months, following a star, bringing their best (Matthew

2:11). Simeon, who had waited his entire life, held the baby in his arms and said, "Now you are letting your servant depart in peace" (Luke 2:29). Each of them received the gift. Each of them was changed by it.

And then there were those who missed it entirely. Herod saw only a threat — and tried to kill the child. The religious leaders knew the prophecies by heart — they could quote Micah, they could point to Bethlehem (Matthew 2:5-6) — but they never walked the few miles to see for themselves. The gift was right in front of them, and they did not receive it.

Before You Open the Presents

On Christmas morning, before the wrapping paper flies, gather your family. Open the Word before you open the gifts. Read the story of Jesus' birth aloud (Luke 2:1-20) — let the youngest child who can read take a part. Sing one verse of a Christmas hymn together: *O Come, All Ye Faithful* or *Hark! The Herald Angels Sing*. Close with a prayer of thanksgiving. Then let the morning begin.

You will find, year after year, that this act of worship at the start of Christmas morning becomes one of the most treasured memories your family carries. It declares, once more, what the tree has been saying all along: the gift is not under the tree. The gift is on the tree — and He is risen.

SESSION 1 · SUNDAY GATHERING ~20 MIN

The Gift Promised

Place the cross at the top of the tree. The promise of a Rescuer was the very first gift God gave — pledged before the gates of Eden closed, foreshadowed in Abraham's son, and named by Isaiah long before there was a manger.

A Promise Before the Gate Closed

Genesis 3:15

The first promise — an offspring who will crush the serpent. The gift is pledged before the garden gate closes.

¹⁵I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.

Genesis 22:1-18

Abraham offers Isaac — "God will provide for himself the lamb." A father's willingness foreshadows the Father's gift.

¹After these things God tested Abraham and said to him, "Abraham!" And he said, "Here I am." ²He said, "Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you." ³So Abraham rose early in the morning, saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and his son Isaac. And he cut the wood for the burnt offering and arose and went to the place of which God had told him. ⁴On the third day Abraham lifted up his eyes and saw the place from afar. ⁵Then Abraham said to his young men, "Stay here with the donkey; I and the boy will go over there and worship and come again to you." ⁶And Abraham took the wood of

the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son. And he took in his hand the fire and the knife. So they went both of them together. ⁷And Isaac said to his father Abraham, "My father!" And he said, "Here I am, my son." He said, "Behold, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" ⁸Abraham said, "God will provide for himself the lamb for a burnt offering, my son." So they went both of them together. ⁹When they came to the place of which God had told him, Abraham built the altar there and laid the wood in order and bound Isaac his son and laid him on the altar, on top of the wood. ¹⁰Then Abraham reached out his hand and took the knife to slaughter his son. ¹¹But the angel of the Lord called to him from heaven and said, "Abraham, Abraham!" And he said, "Here I am." ¹²He said, "Do not lay your hand on the boy or do anything to him, for now I know that you fear God, seeing you have not withheld your son, your only son, from me." ¹³And Abraham lifted up his eyes and looked, and behold, behind him was a ram, caught in a thicket by his horns. And Abraham went and took the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering instead of his son. ¹⁴So Abraham called the name of that place, "The Lord will provide"; as it is said to this day, "On the mount of the Lord it shall be provided." ¹⁵And the angel of the Lord called to Abraham a second time from heaven ¹⁶and said, "By myself I have sworn, declares the Lord, because you have done this and have not withheld your son, your only son, ¹⁷I will surely bless you, and I will surely multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven and as the sand that is on the seashore. And your offspring shall possess the gate of his enemies, ¹⁸and in your offspring shall all the nations of the earth be blessed, because you have obeyed my voice."

Isaiah 9:6-7

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given" — the gift described centuries before it arrives.

⁶For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called

Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.⁷ Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end, on the throne of David and over his kingdom, to establish it and to uphold it with justice and with righteousness from this time forth and forevermore. The zeal of the Lord of hosts will do this.

REFLECT

1. Genesis 3:15 is God's first response to human sin: a promise. Not a sentence, not a threat — a promise. What does it tell you about God that the rescue plan was already in His mouth before the door of Eden swung shut?
2. Abraham was asked to give up the son he loved. The Father did. What does that parallel say about the cost the gift carried for God Himself?
3. Look at the cross now sitting at the top of your tree. The whole story has been climbing toward this. What does it mean that the gift, in the end, looks like a cross?

Close in prayer. Thank the Father for not sparing His own Son, but giving Him up for us all.

SESSION 2 · WEEKDAY ~25 MIN

The Gift Anticipated

A short session. Three psalms and one prophet show how the people of God carried the promise across centuries — singing about a King they had never seen.

The King Promised in Song

Psalm 2

"You are my Son; today I have begotten you. Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage" — the Father's gift to the Son.

¹Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain? ²The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the Lord and against his Anointed, saying, ³"Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us." ⁴He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision. ⁵Then he will speak to them in his wrath, and terrify them in his fury, saying, ⁶"As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill." ⁷I will tell of the decree: The Lord said to me, "You are my Son; today I have begotten you. ⁸Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession. ⁹You shall break them with a rod of iron and dash them in pieces like a potter's vessel." ¹⁰Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth. ¹¹Serve the Lord with fear, and rejoice with trembling. ¹²Kiss the Son, lest he be angry, and you perish in the way, for his wrath is quickly kindled. Blessed are all who take refuge in him.

Psalm 110

"The Lord says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand" — David glimpses a King greater than himself.

¹The Lord says to my Lord: "Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool." ²The Lord sends forth from Zion

your mighty scepter. Rule in the midst of your enemies! ³Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power, in holy garments; from the womb of the morning, the dew of your youth will be yours. ⁴The Lord has sworn and will not change his mind, "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek." ⁵The Lord is at your right hand; he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath. ⁶He will execute judgment among the nations, filling them with corpses; he will shatter chiefs over the wide earth. ⁷He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head.

Isaiah 11:1-10

"A shoot from the stump of Jesse" – the gift will come through a line that looks dead and finished.

¹There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit. ²And the Spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord. ³And his delight shall be in the fear of the Lord. He shall not judge by what his eyes see, or decide disputes by what his ears hear, ⁴but with righteousness he shall judge the poor, and decide with equity for the meek of the earth; and he shall strike the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips he shall kill the wicked. ⁵Righteousness shall be the belt of his waist, and faithfulness the belt of his loins. ⁶The wolf shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the young goat, and the calf and the lion and the fattened calf together; and a little child shall lead them. ⁷The cow and the bear shall graze; their young shall lie down together; and the lion shall eat straw like the ox. ⁸The nursing child shall play over the hole of the cobra, and the weaned child shall put his hand on the adder's den. ⁹They shall not hurt or destroy in all my holy mountain; for the earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord as the waters cover the sea. ¹⁰In that day the root of Jesse, who

shall stand as a signal for the peoples—of him shall the nations inquire, and his resting place shall be glorious.

Malachi 3:1-4

"The Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple" — the last prophetic voice before four centuries of silence.

¹"Behold, I send my messenger, and he will prepare the way before me. And the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple; and the messenger of the covenant in whom you delight, behold, he is coming, says the Lord of hosts. ²But who can endure the day of his coming, and who can stand when he appears? For he is like a refiner's fire and like fullers' soap. ³He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver, and he will purify the sons of Levi and refine them like gold and silver, and they will bring offerings in righteousness to the Lord. ⁴Then the offering of Judah and Jerusalem will be pleasing to the Lord as in the days of old and as in former years.

REFLECT

1. David, Israel's greatest king, sings of a Lord greater than himself. What does it cost a leader to admit that the real King has not come yet?
2. Malachi promises the Lord will *suddenly* come — and then four hundred years of silence follow. What does it mean that "suddenly" in God's vocabulary may include a long, quiet wait?
3. Where in your own life are you currently waiting on a "sudden" answer that hasn't yet come?

Close in prayer. Thank God for the long, faithful patience of His people who waited centuries to see what we celebrate every December.

SESSION 3 · WEEKDAY ~40 MIN

The Gift Arrives

The Christmas story itself — Mary's yes, the manger, Simeon and Anna, the Magi. Read it slowly and let the children hear all of it.

The Arrival

Luke 1:26–56

The annunciation to Mary and her song of praise — "He has done great things for me, and holy is his name."

²⁶In the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God to a city of Galilee named Nazareth, ²⁷to a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. And the virgin's name was Mary. ²⁸And he came to her and said, "Greetings, O favored one, the Lord is with you!" ²⁹But she was greatly troubled at the saying, and tried to discern what sort of greeting this might be. ³⁰And the angel said to her, "Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. ³¹And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you shall call his name Jesus. ³²He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High. And the Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, ³³and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end." ³⁴And Mary said to the angel, "How will this be, since I am a virgin?" ³⁵And the angel answered her, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be called holy--the Son of God. ³⁶And behold, your relative Elizabeth in her old age has also conceived a son, and this is the sixth month with her who was called barren. ³⁷For nothing will be impossible with God." ³⁸And Mary said, "Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word." And the angel departed from her. ³⁹In those days Mary arose and went with haste into the hill country, to a town in

Judah, ⁴⁰and she entered the house of Zechariah and greeted Elizabeth. ⁴¹And when Elizabeth heard the greeting of Mary, the baby leaped in her womb. And Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit, ⁴²and she exclaimed with a loud cry, "Blessed are you among women, and blessed is the fruit of your womb! ⁴³And why is this granted to me that the mother of my Lord should come to me? ⁴⁴For behold, when the sound of your greeting came to my ears, the baby in my womb leaped for joy. ⁴⁵And blessed is she who believed that there would be a fulfillment of what was spoken to her from the Lord." ⁴⁶And Mary said, "My soul magnifies the Lord, ⁴⁷and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior, ⁴⁸for he has looked on the humble estate of his servant. For behold, from now on all generations will call me blessed; ⁴⁹for he who is mighty has done great things for me, and holy is his name. ⁵⁰And his mercy is for those who fear him from generation to generation. ⁵¹He has shown strength with his arm; he has scattered the proud in the thoughts of their hearts; ⁵²he has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate; ⁵³he has filled the hungry with good things, and the rich he has sent away empty. ⁵⁴He has helped his servant Israel, in remembrance of his mercy, ⁵⁵as he spoke to our fathers, to Abraham and to his offspring forever." ⁵⁶And Mary remained with her about three months and returned to her home.

Luke 2:1-21

The birth of Jesus – the gift arrives in poverty and obscurity, wrapped in cloths, laid in a manger, announced to shepherds.

¹In those days a decree went out from Caesar Augustus that all the world should be registered. ²This was the first registration when Quirinius was governor of Syria. ³And all went to be registered, each to his own town. ⁴And Joseph also went up from Galilee, from the town of Nazareth, to Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed, who was with child. ⁶And while they were there, the time came for

her to give birth. ⁷And she gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped him in swaddling cloths and laid him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn. ⁸And in the same region there were shepherds out in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And an angel of the Lord appeared to them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were filled with great fear. ¹⁰And the angel said to them, "Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people. ¹¹For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. ¹²And this will be a sign for you: you will find a baby wrapped in swaddling cloths and lying in a manger." ¹³And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying, ¹⁴"Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace among those with whom he is pleased!" ¹⁵When the angels went away from them into heaven, the shepherds said to one another, "Let us go over to Bethlehem and see this thing that has happened, which the Lord has made known to us." ¹⁶And they went with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the baby lying in a manger. ¹⁷And when they saw it, they made known the saying that had been told them concerning this child. ¹⁸And all who heard it wondered at what the shepherds told them. ¹⁹But Mary treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart. ²⁰And the shepherds returned, glorifying and praising God for all they had heard and seen, as it had been told them. ²¹And at the end of eight days, when he was circumcised, he was called Jesus, the name given by the angel before he was conceived in the womb.

Luke 2:22-40

Simeon and Anna – two people who had waited their whole lives for this gift, and recognized it when it came.

²²And when the time came for their purification according to the Law of Moses, they brought him up to Jerusalem to present him to the Lord ²³(as it is written in the Law of the Lord, "Every male who first opens the womb shall be called holy to the Lord") ²⁴and

to offer a sacrifice according to what is said in the Law of the Lord, "a pair of turtledoves, or two young pigeons." ²⁵Now there was a man in Jerusalem, whose name was Simeon, and this man was righteous and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel, and the Holy Spirit was upon him. ²⁶And it had been revealed to him by the Holy Spirit that he would not see death before he had seen the Lord's Christ. ²⁷And he came in the Spirit into the temple, and when the parents brought in the child Jesus, to do for him according to the custom of the Law, ²⁸he took him up in his arms and blessed God and said, ²⁹"Lord, now you are letting your servant depart in peace, according to your word; ³⁰for my eyes have seen your salvation ³¹that you have prepared in the presence of all peoples, ³²a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to your people Israel." ³³And his father and his mother marveled at what was said about him. ³⁴And Simeon blessed them and said to Mary his mother, "Behold, this child is appointed for the fall and rising of many in Israel, and for a sign that is opposed ³⁵(and a sword will pierce through your own soul also), so that thoughts from many hearts may be revealed." ³⁶And there was a prophetess, Anna, the daughter of Phanuel, of the tribe of Asher. She was advanced in years, having lived with her husband seven years from when she was a virgin, ³⁷and then as a widow until she was eighty-four. She did not depart from the temple, worshiping with fasting and prayer night and day. ³⁸And coming up at that very hour she began to give thanks to God and to speak of him to all who were waiting for the redemption of Jerusalem. ³⁹And when they had performed everything according to the Law of the Lord, they returned into Galilee, to their own town of Nazareth. ⁴⁰And the child grew and became strong, filled with wisdom. And the favor of God was upon him.

Matthew 2

The Magi follow the star, bring gifts, and worship – outsiders travel farther than anyone to honor the King.

¹Now after Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judea in the days of Herod the king, behold, wise men from the east came to Jerusalem, ²saying, "Where is he who has been born king of the Jews? For we saw his star when it rose and have come to worship him." ³When Herod the king heard this, he was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him; ⁴and assembling all the chief priests and scribes of the people, he inquired of them where the Christ was to be born. ⁵They told him, "In Bethlehem of Judea, for so it is written by the prophet: ⁶'And you, O Bethlehem, in the land of Judah, are by no means least among the rulers of Judah; for from you shall come a ruler who will shepherd my people Israel.'" ⁷Then Herod summoned the wise men secretly and ascertained from them what time the star had appeared. ⁸And he sent them to Bethlehem, saying, "Go and search diligently for the child, and when you have found him, bring me word, that I too may come and worship him." ⁹After listening to the king, they went on their way. And behold, the star that they had seen when it rose went before them until it came to rest over the place where the child was. ¹⁰When they saw the star, they rejoiced exceedingly with great joy. ¹¹And going into the house, they saw the child with Mary his mother, and they fell down and worshiped him. Then, opening their treasures, they offered him gifts, gold and frankincense and myrrh. ¹²And being warned in a dream not to return to Herod, they departed to their own country by another way. ¹³Now when they had departed, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream and said, "Rise, take the child and his mother, and flee to Egypt, and remain there until I tell you, for Herod is about to search for the child, to destroy him." ¹⁴And he rose and took the child and his mother by night and departed to Egypt ¹⁵and remained there until the death of Herod. This was to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet, "Out of Egypt I called my son." ¹⁶Then Herod, when he

saw that he had been tricked by the wise men, became furious, and he sent and killed all the male children in Bethlehem and in all that region who were two years old or under, according to the time that he had ascertained from the wise men. ¹⁷Then was fulfilled what was spoken by the prophet Jeremiah: ¹⁸"A voice was heard in Ramah, weeping and loud lamentation, Rachel weeping for her children; she refused to be comforted, because they are no more." ¹⁹But when Herod died, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to Joseph in Egypt, ²⁰saying, "Rise, take the child and his mother and go to the land of Israel, for those who sought the child's life are dead." ²¹And he rose and took the child and his mother and went to the land of Israel. ²²But when he heard that Archelaus was reigning over Judea in place of his father Herod, he was afraid to go there, and being warned in a dream he withdrew to the district of Galilee. ²³And he went and lived in a city called Nazareth, so that what was spoken by the prophets might be fulfilled, that he would be called a Nazarene.

REFLECT

1. Mary's "yes" to God meant her plans, her reputation, even her safety would never be the same. What does her response teach you about what it costs to receive God's gift on His terms?
2. Simeon waited his whole life for one moment with Jesus, and counted it enough. Anna spent her widowhood in the temple, watching for Him. What might "waiting like Simeon and Anna" look like in your own ordinary days?
3. The shepherds were close and came running. The Magi were far and came after months of travel. The religious leaders were nearest of all and never came. Which of those three is closest to your heart's posture this Advent?

Close in prayer. Sit quietly with the wonder that God came as a baby.

SESSION 4 · CHRISTMAS MORNING ~50 MIN

The Gift Revealed and Received

A long final session — the climax of the four weeks. We open by asking who this baby actually was, then turn to the question every person must answer: will you receive the gift? If you can, save the last block for Christmas morning before the gifts are opened.

Who Is This Child?

John 1:1-18

"The Word became flesh and dwelt among us" — the eternal God enters His own creation as a baby.

¹In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. ²He was in the beginning with God. ³All things were made through him, and without him was not any thing made that was made. ⁴In him was life, and the life was the light of men. ⁵The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it. ⁶There was a man sent from God, whose name was John. ⁷He came as a witness, to bear witness about the light, that all might believe through him. ⁸He was not the light, but came to bear witness about the light. ⁹The true light, which gives light to everyone, was coming into the world. ¹⁰He was in the world, and the world was made through him, yet the world did not know him. ¹¹He came to his own, and his own people did not receive him. ¹²But to all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God, ¹³who were born, not of blood nor of the will of the flesh nor of the will of man, but of God. ¹⁴And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth. ¹⁵(John bore witness about him, and cried out, "This was he of whom I said, 'He who comes after me ranks before me, because he was before me.'") ¹⁶For from his fullness we have all received, grace upon grace.

¹⁷For the law was given through Moses; grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. ¹⁸No one has ever seen God; God the only Son, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known.

Colossians 1:15–23

"He is the image of the invisible God... by him all things were created... and in him all things hold together."

¹⁵He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. ¹⁶For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities—all things were created through him and for him. ¹⁷And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together. ¹⁸And he is the head of the body, the church. He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in everything he might be preeminent. ¹⁹For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, ²⁰and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross. ²¹And you, who once were alienated and hostile in mind, doing evil deeds, ²²he has now reconciled in his body of flesh by his death, in order to present you holy and blameless and above reproach before him, ²³if indeed you continue in the faith, stable and steadfast, not shifting from the hope of the gospel that you heard, which has been proclaimed in all creation under heaven, and of which I, Paul, became a minister.

Philippians 2:5–11

"Though he was in the form of God, he did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself" – the cost of the gift.

⁵Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, ⁶who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, ⁷but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men. ⁸And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross. ⁹Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the

name that is above every name, ¹⁰so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, ¹¹and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

Hebrews 1:1-4

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature" – the final Word after all the prophets.

¹Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, ²but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son, whom he appointed the heir of all things, through whom also he created the world. ³He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high, ⁴having become as much superior to angels as the name he has inherited is more excellent than theirs.

REFLECT

1. Colossians says *all things hold together in Him*. The baby in the manger is the one keeping the stars in their courses. How does this reframe what it means that He cried, slept, and needed to be fed?
2. Philippians says Jesus did not *grasp at equality* with God — He let it go for our sake. Where in your life are you grasping at something Jesus would let go of?
3. Hebrews says God spoke through prophets in many ways, but in these last days has spoken to us by His Son. If Jesus is God's final word, what specifically is God saying to your family through Him this Christmas?

The Free Gift

John 3:16–21

"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son" – the gift and the choice it demands.

¹⁶"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.

¹⁷For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but in order that the world might be saved through him.

¹⁸Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only Son of God. ¹⁹And this is the judgment: the light has come into the world, and people loved the darkness rather than the light because their works were evil. ²⁰For everyone who does wicked things hates the light and does not come to the light, lest his works should be exposed. ²¹But whoever does what is true comes to the light, so that it may be clearly seen that his works have been carried out in God."

Romans 6:23

"The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord."

²³For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

2 Corinthians 9:15

"Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!"

¹⁵Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!

1 John 5:1–12

"God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life" – the gift is a person.

¹Everyone who believes that Jesus is the Christ has been born of God, and everyone who loves the Father loves whoever has been

born of him. ²By this we know that we love the children of God, when we love God and obey his commandments. ³For this is the love of God, that we keep his commandments. And his commandments are not burdensome. ⁴For everyone who has been born of God overcomes the world. And this is the victory that has overcome the world--our faith. ⁵Who is it that overcomes the world except the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God? ⁶This is he who came by water and blood--Jesus Christ; not by the water only but by the water and the blood. And the Spirit is the one who testifies, because the Spirit is the truth. ⁷For there are three that testify: ⁸the Spirit and the water and the blood; and these three agree. ⁹If we receive the testimony of men, the testimony of God is greater, for this is the testimony of God that he has borne concerning his Son. ¹⁰Whoever believes in the Son of God has the testimony in himself. Whoever does not believe God has made him a liar, because he has not believed in the testimony that God has borne concerning his Son. ¹¹And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. ¹²Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life.

REFLECT

1. A wage is something you earn. A gift is something you receive. Where in your relationship with God are you still trying to earn what He has already given?
2. 1 John says "the gift is a person." Christianity is not a programme to follow but a Person to receive. What does that change about how you would talk about your faith with someone who doesn't yet believe?

A Life Worthy of the Gift

Ephesians 2:8-10

"By grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God" – you cannot earn it.

⁸For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, ⁹not a result of works, so that no one may boast. ¹⁰For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.

Ephesians 4:1-16

"Walk worthy of the calling to which you have been called" – because He has given us every gift, how then shall we live?

¹I therefore, a prisoner for the Lord, urge you to walk in a manner worthy of the calling to which you have been called, ²with all humility and gentleness, with patience, bearing with one another in love, ³eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. ⁴There is one body and one Spirit--just as you were called to the one hope that belongs to your call-- ⁵one Lord, one faith, one baptism, ⁶one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all. ⁷But grace was given to each one of us according to the measure of Christ's gift. ⁸Therefore it says, "When he ascended on high he led a host of captives, and he gave gifts to men." ⁹(In saying, "He ascended," what does it mean but that he had also descended into the lower regions, the earth? ¹⁰He who descended is the one who also ascended far above all the heavens, that he might fill all things.) ¹¹And he gave the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the shepherds and teachers, ¹²to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, ¹³until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ, ¹⁴so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine, by human cunning, by

craftiness in deceitful schemes. ¹⁵ Rather, speaking the truth in love, we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into Christ, ¹⁶ from whom the whole body, joined and held together by every joint with which it is equipped, when each part is working properly, makes the body grow so that it builds itself up in love.

Romans 12:1-2

"Present your bodies as a living sacrifice" — the gift received becomes a life offered back.

¹ I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship. ² Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect.

REFLECT

1. Paul says we walk worthy of the calling *because* we've been given everything — not so that we will be. What is the difference between obedience that earns and obedience that thanks?
2. Romans 12 calls for a "living sacrifice" — a sacrifice that keeps walking off the altar. What part of your life this coming year would you most need to deliberately put back on the altar each morning?

The Prize Ahead – for Christmas Morning

Philippians 3:12-14

"I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus" – the gift is also a calling.

¹²Not that I have already obtained this or am already perfect, but I press on to make it my own, because Christ Jesus has made me his own. ¹³Brothers, I do not consider that I have made it my own. But one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind and straining forward to what lies ahead, ¹⁴I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.

Revelation 21:1-7

"Behold, I am making all things new... the one who conquers will have this heritage" – the gift fully unwrapped at the end of all things.

¹Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more. ²And I saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. ³And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. ⁴He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away." ⁵And he who was seated on the throne said, "Behold, I am making all things new." Also he said, "Write this down, for these words are trustworthy and true." ⁶And he said to me, "It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. To the thirsty I will give from the spring of the water of life without payment. ⁷The one who conquers will have this heritage, and I will be his God and he will be my son.

Revelation 22:1-5

The Tree of Life, the river of life, the throne of God and of the Lamb – every thread of the story arrives here.

¹Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb ²through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations. ³No longer will there be anything accursed, but the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him. ⁴They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. ⁵And night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.

REFLECT

1. Look at the tree, fully decorated, cross at the top, gifts beneath. Walk through the four weeks aloud – the bare tree, the lights, the ornaments, the cross. What is the single sentence you most want your family to remember from this Advent?
2. The Tree of Life that was lost in Genesis stands open in Revelation 22. Every thread – the tree, the light, the prophecies, the gift – arrives at the same place. Why do you think God made the Bible end where it began?
3. If today were Christmas morning: before any wrapping paper is touched, name out loud one thing each person around the tree is most thankful to God for this year. Then open Luke 2 and read it aloud.

Close in prayer. Thank God for the inexpressible gift. Then – only then – open the others.



BACK MATTER

Further Resources

If you want to deepen your family worship practice beyond this Advent season, these resources are worth your time:

- Donald S. Whitney, *Family Worship* — A short, practical book on establishing and sustaining the habit. (Crossway)
- Joel R. Beeke, *Family Worship* — A brief, pastoral guide from the Dutch Reformed tradition; answers common objections and offers practical direction for getting started. (Reformation Heritage Books)
- *The New City Catechism* — Fifty-two questions and answers drawn from the Reformed confessional tradition, with a free web and mobile app including a children's mode. A natural companion to weekly family worship. (newcitycatechism.com)
- *The ESV Bible Online* — All Scripture readings in this devotional are taken from the English Standard Version. (esv.org)
- *Christmas Tree Devotional* — The companion website for this book, with the same content available freely online for sharing with friends and family. (christmastreedevotional.com)



About This Book



The Tree Tells a Story began as one family's attempt to answer a child's question: "Why do we put a tree inside our house?" The answer turned out to run from Genesis to Revelation.

This book is written for families — for parents who want to lead family worship through Advent without needing a seminary degree, and for grandparents, aunts and uncles, godparents, and friends who want to give a young family the gift of a tradition that grows richer every year.

An online edition of the same content, with linked Scripture passages and additional commentary, lives at christmastreedevoational.com.

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Soli Deo gloria.